

III

Putting It into Practice

Social Movements and Structural Change

Seeing Power in the Collective

“Tinkering is for mechanics, not racial justice advocates,” writes Michelle Alexander in *The New Jim Crow*, “If we can agree that what is needed now, at this critical juncture, is not more tinkering or tokenism, but as King insisted . . . a ‘radical restructuring of our society,’ then perhaps we can also agree that a radical restructuring of our approach to racial justice advocacy is in order as well. . . . I argue that [nothing short of a major social movement](#) can successfully dismantle the new caste system.” For Alexander, like Martin Luther King Jr. before her, real structural change is only possible through widespread collective action. Stop sweating the small stuff and start the revolution.

[Social movements can be powerful](#) and sometimes change doesn’t happen without them. But their power doesn’t come from refusing to tinker or sweat the small stuff. Their effectiveness is grounded not in some big magic power they have but in a million smaller interconnections that bind their members together. Social movement power comes from people speaking to and strategizing with each other—[taking the right small steps](#)—to organize, show up, and keep pushing to create structural conditions that allow these movements to thrive. As is often the case, the wrong kind of tinkering can be distracting, even damaging. The right kind can do wonders.

Social movements like this one are, for many people, what first comes to mind when they think about what brings about big structural change. There’s good reason for this: social movements can and have achieved great things. Still, their odds of success are long, and they can go sideways in all kinds of ways.

Creating a social movement is like lighting a fire—both require essential ingredients. Fires need something flammable, like wood, and oxygen to burn. Without these background conditions in place, no fire would light. Background conditions must be in place for social movements to take off, too. They need public places where their message will be seen, and organizers need networks of social relationships to take advantage of. And money. They always need money.

But those are background conditions. Neither fires nor social movements start themselves. Fires need a spark to start burning. Social movements often need attention-grabbing, catalyzing events to make big leaps in their numbers and influence. And then those people already in the movement, who have already been showing up day after day and are committed to the cause, need to be able to capitalize on those events to fan the spark into real change. But how?

We’ll explore this question by looking at two examples, one highlighting the individuals who create a spark and another highlighting the background conditions that enable and sustain the flames.

“My Kind of Trouble”: How Troublemakers Make Movements

Chris Smalls (figure 9.1) sparked one of the most [shocking and successful unionization movements](#) in the twenty-first century. Growing up in Hackensack, New Jersey, he was an athlete good enough to have NBA aspirations. But he was hit by a car as a teenager, ending his basketball career. He tried community college in Florida but gave it up to make music in New York. Smalls wasn’t doing badly in the hip-hop scene, even touring briefly with chart-topping rapper Meek Mill. But when his wife had twins, Smalls took jobs at Walmart and Home Depot and then added graveyard shifts at FedEx and Target warehouses. In 2015, he started working as a “picker” at an Amazon warehouse in New Jersey. By 2018, he had moved up to assistant manager at the JFK8 warehouse in Staten Island. Then things got interesting.

Smalls says he liked working at Amazon but began noticing what he describes as “deep systemic”

problems with the company. Black and brown people weren't being promoted, caregivers with kids or family at home weren't given any help, and safety protocols were inadequate and ignored. On March 30, 2020, as COVID-19 ripped through New York City, Smalls collaborated with fellow JFK8 employee Derrick Palmer to arrange a walkout to demand personal protective equipment and better quarantine protections.



Figure 9.1

Chris Smalls. Brendan McDermid/Reuters.

During this hellish first three months of the pandemic, about 20,000 New Yorkers died from COVID-19. [According to the CDC, the average fatality rate in New York City](#) during this period for anyone who contracted it was almost 10 percent, though that number was even higher for Black and Hispanic New Yorkers. Amazon's response to the walkout for better protection was callous; it fired Smalls that same day. The company's senior vice president for policy and press, Jay Carney (who was formerly press secretary for President Trump), offered as justification that Smalls had violated Amazon's social distancing guidelines.

Along with Palmer and a small group of dedicated coworkers, Smalls responded by organizing. They started The Congress of Essential Workers (TCOEW), which orchestrated May Day strikes and "Prime Day" protests. They marched to Amazon CEO Jeff Bezos's mansion in Beverly Hills on Prime Day, demanding \$2/hour raises in front of his \$165 million home. Public support for Smalls and TCOEW exploded when an internal Amazon memo referring to Smalls as "not smart or articulate" was leaked to *Vice*. According to the reporting, the company's General Counsel David Zapolsky thought it would make good PR to paint Smalls—who didn't shy away from [dressing "Black,"](#) wearing sweats, sneakers, and durags to meetings and public appearances—as "the face of the entire union/organizing movement."

All this caught the attention of New York's Attorney General Letitia James, who opened an investigation into Smalls's firing, ultimately finding it illegal. New York Mayor Bill DeBlasio commented on the case, as did Representative Alexandra Ocasio-Cortez. Eventually, nine US Senators sent a letter to Amazon demanding information about the firing of whistleblowers like Smalls.

Meanwhile, Smalls, Palmer, and other organizers focused on gathering signatures for a union authorization vote. The audacity of this effort is hard to overstate. Amazon is infamous for its aggressive and successful union busting. Even more impressive, Smalls and company did it without the affiliation of a national union, which one long-time labor organizer described to us as “bananas.” Nevertheless, Smalls sat in a tent by the JFK8 bus stop day after day, providing workers information about the benefits of unionization. Palmer strategically sought out leaders of social cliques. “What I’ll do is study a group of friends and go to the leader of the pack,” he said. “Whatever the leader says, the rest of the group is going to do.”

Angelika Maldonado was another early organizer. Since Amazon had a policy prohibiting workers from talking about the union on company time, she made sure someone was always in the break room to field questions. A chat group, on the mobile messaging app Telegram, grew with curious members, though as Maldonado put it, “to be honest, the chat wasn’t that big a concern for us; the main thing was the face-to-face interactions. I think that’s really what got the union going.”

It took nine months, until January of the following year, to gather enough signatures to petition the National Labor Relations Board to hold a vote. On April 1, 2022, the workers at JFK8 voted 2,654 to 2,131 in favor of unionization, and with that vote, the first union at a US Amazon warehouse was approved. Smalls said, “We want to thank Jeff Bezos for going to space, because while he was up there we were organizing a union.” At a visit to the White House a month later, President Biden told Smalls, “I like you, you’re my kind of trouble.”

This win didn’t by itself overcome the systemic problems Smalls noticed when he started at Amazon, of course. Even replicating the group’s initial success was difficult. Smalls’s Amazon Labor Union helped to organize a unionization vote at another Staten Island warehouse, LDJ5, in May of 2022, but there the warehouse workers voted it down. Labor historian Janice Fine put it in context: “The history of unions is always about [failing forward](#) . . . workers trying, workers losing, workers trying again.”

If they eventually succeed, unions can do a lot of good. They increase wages and benefits for workers, and as we saw in chapter 5, they can also be powerful locales for building trust and friendship across social differences like race or religion. They provide unique opportunities for people of different backgrounds to work cooperatively together toward shared goals. Diverse unions have acted like [schools for cross-racial cooperation](#) for a long time.

On top of reducing the racial biases of their members, unions can boost support for policies that promote racial equity in the workforce. When white waterfront workers decided to strike in post-Civil War New Orleans, they realized they needed to work across racial lines to prevent companies from simply turning to Black workers. Three Black and white unions formed a consortium—the Triple Alliance—that later shut down the Port of New Orleans and won major gains for workers. They also adopted a race-conscious policy called “[half-and-half](#)” that required crews to include equal numbers of Black and white workers.

Of course, unions aren’t always forces for good (see chapter 5). Labor unions for mining, fracking, and harvesting fossil fuels have been some of the most powerful actors [standing in the way](#) of state and federal climate legislation for decades. They can also be internally corrupt. Trade unions have a long history of acting in racially and sexually discriminatory ways. Police unions reflexively defend members even in the most egregious cases of the abuse of power.

But at their best, unions can be fertile ground for promoting intergroup harmony, both/and thinking, and initiating and sustaining social change. Their influence has been in decline for the past couple decades, but there are signs that the decline is slowing. Indeed, 2022 was a banner year. Unionization efforts won more elections in the first half of 2022 than in any of the previous 20 years, with those 641 elections achieving a success rate of over 75 percent. And the share of Americans who say they approve of unions rose to over 70 percent, higher than at any time since 1965. Although the overall percentage of American workers in a union still declined slightly in 2022, there’s room for optimism that more organizers like Smalls can start bending back the curve.

Sparks go out quickly without the right stuff to burn. But without any kind of spark to ignite it, there’s no fire. Movements need the right people at the right place at the right time. Smalls, Palmer, and

Maldonado were those people for JFK8.

Latin America's Green Tide and the Structural Preconditions of a Social Movement

Predicting those people and times and places is difficult, to say the least. It's hard to tell if the oxygen is there, ready to burn, until afterwards. Many sparks fail to start fires where conditions seem right, while others flare up into fires where nobody would have expected. Few movements in recent history provide as good an example of this as the Green Tide.

In 2021, Texas enacted what were then the most severe abortion restrictions in the United States, banning all procedures after six weeks of pregnancy. Shortly after, Mexican feminist activists sprang into action, sending abortion pills to Texan women and offering free advice over the phone about how to use them. These activists upend a long-standing image of the United States as more progressive on reproductive rights than its neighbors to the south. And they also represent just a sliver of an increasingly [successful movement across Latin America](#). For example, Argentina's Congress legalized abortion in 2020, and Colombia's Constitutional Court and Mexico's Supreme Court decriminalized it in 2022 and 2023, respectively.

This [Green Tide movement](#), named after the color of the bandannas worn by members, started in Argentina in the early aughts and has been spreading through Latin America since. Much of the Green Tide's success is connected to urbanization, as Latin American cities have grown quickly and the region is now 80 percent urban (by population). Movement activism there relies on interconnected, densely populated areas for public displays of messaging and meeting up. Political graffiti and murals are ubiquitous. Shared physical space is easy to overlook, but it's a crucial ingredient. Much like union members who work side by side, people who live in the same city neighborhood have more opportunities to witness others in successful acts of resistance. As we discussed in chapters 5 and 7, these kinds of shoulder-to-shoulder interactions are vital both for reducing prejudice and for persuading people that resistance is alive and thriving. These are just a few of the key background structures that, when in place, provide wind to fan the flames of a growing movement.

Gains made in economic independence and social mobility were also key background factors. Many of these trends predated the stunning twenty-first-century growth of feminist movements in the region and so preceded the Green Tide. The size of these social and economic gains reflected how far many Latin American countries still had to go. Through the better part of the twentieth century, [women's freedom to work was severely restricted](#). Legislation prevented them from opening bank accounts, signing contracts, and appearing in court. Men made the laws, holding more than 90 percent of lower or unicameral legislature seats through most of the 1990s.

Beginning in the 1970s, in part due to reductions in teen pregnancy, gains in education, and spikes in economic insecurity, more women joined the labor market. Movement organizing began to [rise along with the number of working women](#). These changes reinforced positive feedback loops, like those we sketched in the previous chapter, where success begets success.

Women are taking more leadership positions, too. Improvements in education, reproductive justice, and labor power have corresponded with greater gender parity in legislative representation under both left- and right-wing governments. As of 2023, eleven countries in Latin America have passed reforms [requiring gender parity](#), for example, among candidates for the legislature. Women comprise around half of at least one chamber of congress in Argentina, Bolivia, Costa Rica, Ecuador, Mexico, and Nicaragua. As Mexican Senator Adriana Díaz put it, “[it] is not making space [for women], it is not implementing a quota, it is sharing in decision-making so that together we [men and women] can be co-responsible in the true development and advance of democracy.”

Changes in global economic conditions have pushed more women into urban centers and the labor market, which highlighted inequities in their political rights, which fostered organizing, which led to successful structural changes in political representation, which in turn gave women a greater voice in Latin

American politics and culture. This greater voice feeds back into the process, inspiring more organizers to persist in the struggle for gender justice.

The Green Tide has its own charismatic fire starters, like Sibila Sotomayor Van Rysseghem, Daffne Valdés Vargas, and Paula Cometa Stange. Together, they make up the Chilean feminist, trans-inclusive collective LasTesis. After they performed their protest song, “Un Violador en Tu Camino” (“A Rapist in Your Path”), in front of a police station in 2019, the song went viral on social media. Soon, huge crowds of blindfolded women were singing and [performing the coordinated dance](#) in major cities like Santiago, Mexico City, and Bogotá.

All kinds of factors need to come together for a movement to grow and succeed. It requires the right leaders, where “right” includes personality traits like moral charisma and the creativity to bring people together. Those leaders also need to fit well into the structures and circumstances in which they operate. They have to possess the know-how that will allow them to align their strategies with the specifics of their situation. When it all comes together, social movements have the potential to rise in visibility very quickly.

Still, even when all these stars align, movements fail far more than they succeed. But there are lessons to be learned in those cases too.

Learning from Movement Failures

[Social movements come up short](#) for all kinds of reasons. But a common flaw is getting the relations between systems and people wrong. Consider a few examples.

#MeToo and the Perils of Overly Individualist Movements

#MeToo took off in 2017 after Alyssa Milano’s tweet on October 15 (figure 9.2). The tweet appeared about a week after stories were published in the *New York Times* and the *New Yorker* about Harvey Weinstein’s long history of sexual abuse. Within two weeks, [1.7 million tweets](#) originating in over eighty-five countries had used the #MeToo hashtag.

A less well-known figure in the story of #MeToo is Tarana Burke, a Black organizer from the Bronx who had worked for decades fighting sexual violence. By 2017, she’d been leading what she called “[Me Too](#)” [workshops](#) aimed at raising “empowerment through empathy” for eleven years. These created a safe space for survivors of sexual violence, a space where, as Burke puts it, “healing is a form of action” and “taking action helps us to heal.” When Burke learned that #MeToo was exploding online, her first reaction was understandably frustrated: “This can’t happen,” I said through my tears. “Not like this! Y’all know if these white women start using this hashtag, and it gets popular, they will never believe that a Black woman in her forties from the Bronx has been building a movement for the same purposes, using those exact words, for years now. It will be over.”



Figure 9.2

The minimization of Burke’s role in #MeToo can be viewed as a parable about social movements in the age of internet virality. On the one hand, #MeToo was a powerful and progressive moment in American history. It educated the country about the pervasiveness of sexual violence and misconduct, much as Burke had set out to do eleven years earlier. It helped bring down serial abusers and rapists in high-profile

positions, from producer Harvey Weinstein to New York Governor Andrew Cuomo. It proved how quickly an idea can catch on, precisely because we are all so tightly interconnected, making up the increasingly dense fabric of each other's situations.

But #MeToo was no unmitigated success. Although it led to the ousting of a handful of extremely powerful individuals, critics claim its impact on the lives of ordinary people has been small. Most of its victories, they say, were symbolic. For starters, [rates of sexual harassment and assault](#) have not declined. Some limited evidence suggests that while the targets and victims of these behaviors are a little more likely to report them, upticks in reporting have not corresponded with more perpetrators being held accountable. And those who report being targeted remain just as likely to suffer retaliation: further assaults, gaslighting, demotions, firings.

Recall how Angelika Maldonado downplayed the value of the virtual when she was organizing Amazon workers. What really “got the union going,” she said, “was the face-to-face interactions.” Maldonado's lesson puts in stark relief the contrast between the high-profile online discourse surrounding #MeToo and the near invisibility of grassroots activists like Tarana Burke, who had been working week after week on building in-person connections.

Genuine progress involves not just one-off takedowns of celebrity wrongdoers but also nationwide changes in the conditions of everyday people's lives. Assessing the overall effects of #MeToo will require nuanced and long-term study, but it's reasonable to ask how much #MeToo has moved from conversation and symbol to collective action and structural change.

In fact, there's some reason to think that things have gone in the other direction. In 1994, 58 percent of high school seniors disagreed with the idea that “it's usually better for everyone involved if the man is the achiever outside the home and the woman takes care of the home and family.” By 2014, that number had [fallen to 42 percent](#). As of 2017, only 25 percent of millennial women, and 15 percent of millennial men, consider themselves feminists.

Jump ahead to 2022, five years after the spark of Alyssa Milano's initial tweet, and the needle didn't appear to have moved. A poll by the Southern Poverty Law Center found that 46 percent of Democratic men under fifty believed that feminism “has done more harm than good,” and 60 percent of this same group believed that “men should be represented and valued more in our society.” While just 10 percent of older Democratic women shared this dim view of feminism, the percentage more than doubled to 23 percent among younger Democratic women. The rise in support for Trump since 2016 among both young men and women of all racial and ethnic groups suggests tolerance for sexism is growing.

The public turn against feminism coincides with a broader trend of legal and political setbacks for gender justice that stretches back decades. Many laws and norms protecting the lives of women and pregnant people have been rolled back, the most notable (so far) being the US Supreme Court's 2022 decision in *Dobbs v. Jackson's Women's Health Organization* that rejected the Constitutional right to abortion. While *Dobbs* sparked plenty of outrage, and 2022 voters in several states from California to Kansas responded by voting in support of reproductive justice, it is still too early—at the time we're writing this—to tell whether a sustained, organized, and effective resistance movement is emerging.

The overturning of *Roe* was not caused by inadequacies in the #MeToo movement. But it is still fair to ask whether #MeToo has (so far) helped stem the overall tide of setbacks—either in terms of individual attitudes or in terms of laws and structures. A common and not unreasonable view of #MeToo is that in its sudden rise, it became too white, too online, and too individualist. Some think it erred by focusing too much attention on celebrity villains and not enough on systemic change and that the solutions it offered were about overcoming personal traumas rather than creating collective action.

Some skeptics of #MeToo also criticized the movement for embracing a professionalized version of feminism associated with Facebook's former chief operating officer, Sheryl Sandberg. In her 2013 bestseller, *Lean In: Women, Work, and the Will to Lead*, Sandberg implored women to assert themselves to get ahead, but her critics noted that the details of her message indicated that it was mainly aimed at highly

educated and otherwise privileged women. Like so many other examples we've explored in this book, *Lean In* has been criticized for foisting responsibility onto individual women to better “assert themselves” in response to sexism, rather than turning attention to the sexist people and structures standing in their way.

As Susan Faludi said in *The New York Times*,

[Pop feminism's Achilles' heel](#) is a faith in the power of the individual star turn over communal action, the belief that a gold-plated influencer plus a subscription list plus some viral content can be alchemized into mass activism. The #MeToo campaign, as it evolved, was driven in no small measure by that faith—likewise Ms. Sandberg's “Lean In,” a “movement” of free-standing C-suite aspirants, each of whom was instructed to defeat her “internal obstacles” to get ahead as an individual rather than organize to defeat external forces. That ethic made it attractive to the professional class but of little use to the great mass of working women.

Data seems to back up these observations. After the 2016 election, one poll found that only 20 percent of millennial women rejected the idea that feminism “is about personal choice, not politics.”

We can't help but wonder whether a larger hurdle that #MeToo failed to overcome was the individualist mindset so entrenched in American culture. Indeed, [Faludi's both/and diagnosis](#) is that “the new individualist style of feminism so often cast itself as an alternative instead of as an aid to the old-fashioned communal activism.”

From another perspective, #MeToo may not have been individualist enough, or at least it may not have paid attention to the right individuals in the right way. It failed to credit and celebrate hardworking organizers like Tarana Burke, who had been taking activism beyond hashtags for a long time.

Unintended Consequences

Social movements, like so much else in life, don't always go as planned. Sometimes their members pursue structural changes that sound great in theory only to see their efforts backfire when they run up against the complicated and conflicted minds of actual people. Even what seems like an obvious fix can make things worse. As we saw in chapter 8, sometimes a scheme to kill off cobras just creates more cobras.

A challenge for people in the United States who have spent time in jail is that many employers can, and sometimes must (by law), ask all applicants to “check a box” if they have a criminal record. As a result, formerly incarcerated people have a very hard time finding employment, which in turn makes them more likely to become desperate to make ends meet, re-offend, and then end up back in prison.

In one [field study done in Milwaukee](#), the odds of getting a callback for an interview were 34 percent for white male applicants with no criminal record but only 17 percent for white men with a criminal record. The odds were 14 percent for Black male applicants without a record but only 5 percent for Black men with a record. Follow-up studies in New York City found much the same: people with a criminal record—especially Black and Latinx people—face a terrible challenge in landing a job. In the NYC studies, nineteen out of twenty formerly incarcerated people of color didn't make it past the initial screening, even just to land an interview, let alone secure the job.

An intuitive solution? “Ban the box.” Restrict employers' ability to demand that applicants report their criminal records. This fix is typically construed as structural since it aims to increase racial equity without having to persuade anyone to be less prejudiced. It's changing the context of employer decision-making without requiring anyone to change their biases. As of October 2021, and as the result of a lot of movement organizing, [37 states and over 150 cities](#) have adopted some form of ban the box policy.

These were celebrated as victories, but they may not have delivered what advocates hoped. One study compared employment rates in regions before and after banning the box and found that low-skilled Black and Latinx men were marginally [less likely to be employed](#) after banning the box than before. Banning the

box in this case appeared to reduce discrimination against formerly incarcerated people but increase discrimination against applicants of color with clean records. Why?

A plausible hypothesis is that if employers aren't sure about whether a candidate has a criminal record, then that uncertainty provides an opening for racial bias to exert more influence on their decisions. Employers who cannot ask up front about criminal histories may (consciously or unconsciously) just assume that Black and brown applicants have sketchy backgrounds. Researchers point to "a growing literature showing that well-intentioned policies that remove information about negative characteristics can do more harm than good." As Michelle Alexander put it, "banning the box is not enough. We must also get rid of the mind-set that puts Black men 'in the box.'"

The social world is complicated, and the effects of even simple policies that seem like they can't miss are difficult to foresee. Banning the box inadvertently gives people's racial biases more room to operate. It provides another reminder that everything in the US is two degrees removed from race, that racial prejudice is never far from the scene.

Examples like this also illustrate once again the Return of the Allegedly Irrelevant. Some critics of individualist approaches to structural racism endorse "policy change over mental change" and for "policies that directly increase racial equality and participation" rather than "changing attitudes." They hold that the biases in our heads are irrelevant to creating bigger, far-reaching change. These critics might, we imagine, have advocated for ban the box campaigns in the following way:

If we want to fight oppression against formerly incarcerated people of color, our movement shouldn't bother trying to change individuals' racial biases. These prejudices are irrelevant and are too hard to dislodge anyway. We shouldn't bother with moral persuasion. Instead, we should make simple and direct structural changes to our racist hiring procedures. The main obstacle to this isn't prejudice; it's the existing structures of power. So, we need a massive social movement to win power.

But the reality of banning the box shows otherwise. The allegedly irrelevant returns. Even "successful" efforts to change hiring procedures can make things worse when they fail to account for individual factors like psychological biases.

The critics might double down. Rather than grant that individuals' prejudices are relevant after all, they might offer a different diagnosis of the shortcomings of ban the box campaigns: they're just a tweak. They're a minor change and so are [not structural enough](#). Real structural change, they might claim, is not just about which boxes people have to tick on a form. That's the sort of incremental tinkering Michelle Alexander thinks we should leave to the mechanics. Real structural change involves deeper and more wide-reaching transformations to prevailing social practices, like, say, passing a new amendment to the US Constitution. Surely that would do it.

Failed Successes

Americans used to drink [a lot of alcohol](#). One reason was that drinking water often made people sick, and beer was generally safer because fermentation kills bacteria. This led the National Women's Christian Temperance Union to campaign in the late 1800s for structures making safe water easier to drink: public water fountains. So-called temperance fountains sprang up in cities across the country. The James Fountain in Union Square in NYC started off as a temperance fountain. In Washington, DC, a fountain simply known as *the* "Temperance Fountain" has a life-sized stone heron on top of a pair of carved dolphins, [from whose snouts visitors drank water](#). But structural changes to the water supply weren't enough to stem the flow of booze. The temperance movement set their sights higher.

The Eighteenth Amendment to the US Constitution, ratified in 1919, made it illegal to produce, transport, or sell "intoxicating" liquors. Prohibition ensued. While it officially started in 1919, it was the result of a century of movement building and hard-fought political struggle. It's probably more accurate to

say “movements” since the temperance movement that led to the Eighteenth Amendment was entwined with many strands of American politics, from progressive populism to religious revivals to racist nativism.

Some of the issues bringing this coalition together feel anachronistic—especially the moralistic ones about the inherent evils of any amount of alcohol—but others remain familiar. The Anti-Saloon League (ASL)—the group most focused on getting political results at the time—tied excessive drinking to domestic and sexual violence. In this it seems they were right: domestic abuse [sharply declined during Prohibition](#). No surprise that women were disproportionate supporters of the movement.

But alcohol did not stay illegal for long. In 1933, the Twenty-First Amendment repealed the Eighteenth, a mere fourteen years after Prohibition began. It’s the only amendment ever passed in the US that repealed another amendment. One reason for its unpopularity was that Prohibition fueled organized crime. Keeping a whole industry outlawed in the midst of the Great Depression was also terrible economics. Banning alcohol was effective in getting people to drink less, even leading to 20 percent declines in deaths from liver cirrhosis, but that wasn’t enough to make Prohibition popular.

In fact, the Eighteenth Amendment never enjoyed popular support, even when it was initially passed. That legislative victory was the result of a highly mobilized and politically effective interest group. Their initial success provides an excellent example of the way a well-organized social movement can achieve its goals even when the democratic will of the majority opposes them. By forming coalitions with anyone who would sign onto their one single issue—from Klansmen to liberal internationalists—and by raising enormous amounts of money, the ASL was able to dictate terms to politicians. As one historian put it, they could say, “Are you with us or are you against us? . . . if you are against us we will defeat you. And if you are with us [we will elect you](#).”

But in the end, Prohibition turned out to be a colossal “failed success.” It’s notable because, for many Americans at least, nothing epitomizes the fantasy of “deep” and “durable” structural change like amending the Constitution itself. Think for a moment about how hard it is to even imagine the US passing an amendment in the twenty-first century about anything, let alone a momentous one that secured reproductive freedom for all or curbed the right to bear arms. On top of that, even if such an amendment were passed, if it was unpopular enough, or triggered a strong enough backlash, then it could also be repealed. When people don’t support the changes they make, even amendments can be amended. And even if they are popular, it remains possible for nine unelected lifetime judges to [reinterpret clearly written amendments](#) in ways that eviscerate them.

The point is decidedly *not* that anyone should give up trying to make changes to the system. Rather, the point is that the pursuit of structural change is no alternative to the hard and grinding work of persuading our peers to support that change. Even momentous successes that are the culmination of decades of organizing can fail to stick when they get the people wrong. Change endures when it’s etched just as deeply into our hearts and minds as it is into our most basic laws.

Prohibition didn’t last long, and temperance fountains also went by the boards. Cities couldn’t maintain them, and people found them unsightly. *The New York Times* called them “dismal and horrific effigies” and “crimes against . . . taste . . . and the common sense of mankind, warping the aesthetic instincts of babes unborn and perverting the ideas of infants.” Few remained operational for long.

Of Minds and Movements

An important lesson of unsuccessful structural reforms is that even when they are achieved, they aren’t guaranteed to last. Even the most apparently rock-solid changes to the founding documents of a country are durable only insofar as people support—or at least tolerate—them.

This is no vindication of the priority of individuals over structures. Even the power of the US president to enact reform is constrained in countless ways: by Congress’s support of the president’s agenda, by a Supreme Court that might overturn executive orders, by the staff who give the president information about what various policies will do, and so on. A justice of the Supreme Court might get outvoted by other justices. Even if you as an individual had the power to snap your fingers like the Avengers’ nemesis

Thanos and change social reality itself, someone else might change it all back. Some social changes do last longer than others, though. The next chapter looks to figure out why.

Lighting the Spark: Social Identity, Collective Action, and Making a Difference

A Movement Born of Murder

After getting out of school on March 3, 1931, Harlon Carter arrived at his home in Laredo, Texas, to find his mother in distress. She claimed to have seen three “Hispanic” boys hovering around their property. Could they be behind the recent theft of the family car? Carter, who was seventeen years old, grabbed his father’s shotgun and went out to find them. The three boys he found at a nearby swimming hole—who may or may not have been the three his mother said she saw—were between the ages of twelve and fifteen. Carter insisted that they return with him to his house. The oldest, Ramón Casiano, refused and then reportedly pulled out a knife and told Carter to leave them alone. Carter responded by shooting Casiano in the center of his chest, killing him almost instantly. He was eventually [convicted of murder](#) and sentenced to three years in prison.

Sixty-one years after Carter murdered fifteen-year-old Ramón Casiano, the National Rifle Association named its most prestigious award after him. The [Harlon B. Carter Legislative Achievement Award](#) is given each year by the NRA to a politician who has most loyally worked to prevent gun restrictions from being enacted in the United States.

Despicable as he was, Carter deserves to be the award’s namesake. [He spearheaded the transformation of the NRA](#) from a marginal hobby group for hunters into a major player in American politics. Carter took advantage of one of the deepest features of human psychology: people want—need—to feel like they belong. As we explored in chapter 6, it’s human nature to be social. What Carter’s story exemplifies is the power of using this part of human nature in the service of social change. Nothing lights the fire like appealing to “group identity,” the sense of who *we* are and what *we’re* all about.

Whatever one thinks about the NRA’s values and aims (shocker: we’re not fans!), it has been extraordinarily successful in its pursuit of them. It would be a mistake to not try and learn from their success.

The NRA’s Remarkable Rise to Power

Not long after being released from prison in 1935, Carter joined the newly formed US Border Patrol. He rose through the ranks and by 1954 had taken control of an overtly racist and xenophobic federal deportation program named [“Operation Wetback,”](#) which carried out the new-for-its-time idea of military-style tactics to remove Mexican immigrants from the US. Carter joined the national board of the NRA in 1951 and served as president from 1965 to 1967.

This was a transitional time for the organization. For decades, it had been a sportsman’s association, focused on hunting, marksmanship, and recreational shooting. By the time Carter took over, the issue of gun control was gaining steam across the country. The murders of prominent leaders from John and Bobby Kennedy to Malcolm X and Martin Luther King Jr. led people to question whether high-powered weapons should be accessible to the public.

But many of the concerns about guns—and the concerns that got the most traction—became racialized. In the summer of 1967, American cities like Detroit and Newark had been wracked by waves of intense protests focused on racial discrimination. [A 1968 federal report](#) laid much of the blame for the violence on the easy availability of guns.

California’s response was one of the first and clearest. It was set in motion on May 2, 1967, when thirty

armed members of the Black Panthers approached the statehouse in Sacramento to demand justice. Before entering, Bobby Seale (who two years later would cofound the Black Panthers' Free Breakfast for School Children Program; see chapter 3) told the crowd of reporters, "[Black people have begged](#), prayed, petitioned, demonstrated, and everything else to get the racist power structure of America to right the wrongs which have historically been perpetuated against Black people." To protect themselves "against this terror," the Panthers claimed the right to carry loaded guns in public. In response, California's overwhelmingly white legislature immediately created new gun restrictions.

On July 28, 1967, Republican Governor Ronald Reagan signed the Mulford Act, which prohibited carrying loaded firearms without a permit. Reagan said he saw "no reason why on the street today a citizen should be carrying loaded weapons" and that guns were a "ridiculous way to solve problems that have to be solved among people of good will." In a move that would be unimaginable a few decades later, the NRA endorsed the bill.

When the NRA also came out in support of parts of the federal Gun Control Act of 1968—which quickly followed California's law—Carter broke with the group. He wrote a letter to the NRA membership articulating ideas now all too familiar to twenty-first-century Americans. "We can win it on a simple concept," he wrote. "No compromise. No gun legislation." He opposed background checks for gun purchasers, arguing that the possibility of guns in the hands of "violent criminals" and the "mentally ill" is the "price we pay for freedom."

About a decade later, at an infamous all-night NRA membership meeting, Carter emerged victorious from what became known as the "Revolt in Cincinnati." He and his followers voted out the leadership and changed the organization's bylaws. Over the next few years, Carter led the Institute for Legislative Action, the NRA's lobbying wing, transforming it into a powerhouse dedicated to defeating gun control. NRA membership tripled during this time, and [its budget and influence skyrocketed](#). Carter's villainy aside, it's hard to deny his success.

Before researching this, we had assumed the problem was just how deeply Americans love their guns. But this turns out to be too simple. A remarkable feature of the NRA's influence is how persistently unpopular its platform has been. Most [Americans want more gun control](#). In 2019, 60 percent of Americans said that gun laws should be made stricter, while only 11 percent said they should be made less strict.

While there are partisan splits over guns, there is overwhelming bipartisan support for specific restrictions. Ninety-three percent of Democrats and 82 percent of Republicans favor making background checks mandatory for private gun sales and at gun shows. In fact, clear majorities of both gun owners in general (61.6 percent) as well as *Republican gun owners* (57.4 percent) believe that people should have to pass a safety course before buying a gun. And yet restrictions like these have been repeatedly blocked. Compared to other countries, what gun laws the US does have on the books are weak. Their laxness is especially striking given how outrageously unparalleled gun violence is in the US (figure 10.1).

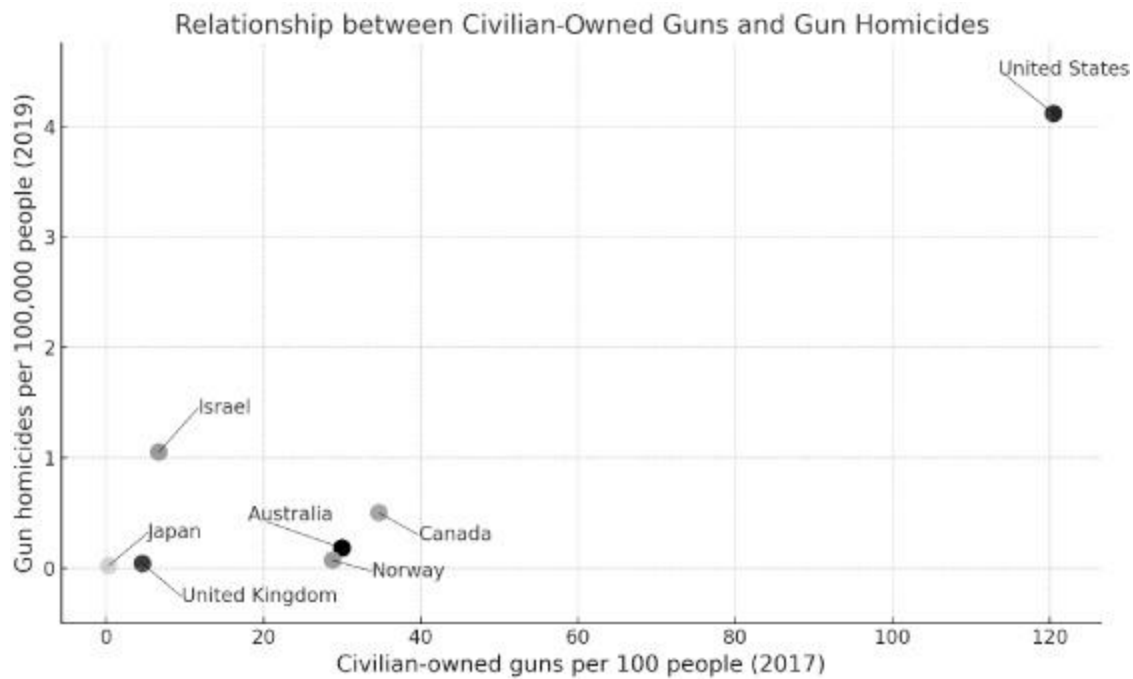


Figure 10.1

Gun ownership and homicide rates in developed countries. Small Arms Survey.

We had also assumed that the gun lobby was massively well-funded. But it turns out that much of the NRA's influence [predates its political spending](#). Other interest groups spend far more than the NRA and come away with far less to show for it.

For years we also expected that the mounting number of tragic experiences with guns would eventually turn the tide. Had you offered us a bet that an event like the Sandy Hook massacre would be severe enough to finally push through significant gun control legislation, we would have taken it. We similarly would have guessed that victims of gun violence in the gun-owning community itself would make a difference. Gun owners remain far more likely to die from gun violence than non-gun owners, and the lion's share of gun-related deaths in the US are due to accidents, escalating fights, and suicide. An example: having a handgun in the house makes someone seven times more likely to be killed by their spouse or partner. Women make up 84 percent of victims in these domestic partner killings. But the proximity of gun owners to tragic violence hasn't moved the needle.

The Rifleman: From Killer to Kingmaker

How has the NRA managed to hold the line with public opinion, tens of thousands of personal tragedies, and regular eruptions of mass outrage stacked against it? Matthew Lacombe, a political scientist at Case Western Reserve University, took a novel route to answering this question. He analyzed seventy-nine years of *American Rifleman*, the official magazine of the NRA, along with decades of letters written to the editors of four major newspapers by NRA members. He wanted to understand how the NRA framed discussions of gun control and used that framing to win power.

Lacombe concluded that the NRA succeeded by crafting and [publicizing a specific social identity](#). Over and over, articles in *American Rifleman* emphasized the positive traits of gun owners and talked about them as a group of people who shared a distinctive identity. The articles also used the language of conflict, threat, and victimhood. Gun owners were depicted as a besieged group whose rights were at risk of being taken away by outsiders.

Lacombe traced this identity- and conflict-soaked language from the NRA's communications with its

members directly into the opinion pieces those members sent to newspapers. *American Rifleman* was the source of four of the five most identity-related terms and phrases—including popular terms like “antigunner” and “freedom loving”—found in opinion pieces. Two-thirds of the editorials portrayed gun rights as under threat. Nearly all the editorials Lacombe analyzed—90 percent of them—discussed gun policies, and 75 percent discussed policy in identity-related terms.

However, the NRA did more than just work up a vocabulary of identity around guns. It also developed infrastructure in which that identity could grow. It built a community. A whole latticework of local organizations and events was created to cultivate and sustain that community. The national organization tied official membership to tangible benefits, from discount cards to life insurance. The NRA’s investment in all this produced an increasingly cohesive group of motivated activists.

As members of the community grew to understand themselves as gun owners and advocates of gun rights, they increasingly became “single-issue” voters. A politician’s stand on guns became the only issue that mattered. The NRA transformed gun owners from people who would merely check a box on a survey saying that they supported gun rights to those for whom a politician’s stance on gun rights was a dealmaker or a dealbreaker. Over 70 percent of Americans who prefer lax gun laws say they’d *never* vote for a candidate advocating stronger regulations. Compare that to people who favor stricter laws. Almost 70 percent admit they’d consider [voting for a pro-gun candidate](#) under some circumstances.

The first two essential ingredients to the NRA’s success were creating an identity around gun ownership and building social structures to leverage that identity into reliably motivated activists and voters. Harlon Carter’s Institute for Legislative Action added the third: cultivating relationships with Republican elites. To put it bluntly, the NRA [trades votes for policy positions](#). Just like the teetotaling ASL before it, the organization credibly tells political leaders what positions to take. If they agree, they’re blessed with the support of a large bloc of reliable voters. If they disagree, they’re threatened with that bloc’s ire. The politics around guns in the United States would never be the same.

None of this is some highly guarded industry secret like the Facebook algorithm or the recipe for Coca-Cola. NRA leaders have basically said it’s what they were trying to do. In fact, the historian Daniel Okrent argues that the NRA simply “copied to the letter” the tactics of the ASL. Over the years, other groups—from the Tea Party to the Sunrise Movement—have gone on to take pages from the NRA’s playbook.

The Sunrise Movement, for example, was inspired by a widely circulated “postmortem” assessment of the failed attempt to pass the 2009 Waxman-Markey cap-and-trade bill. That document attributed the failure to the absence of a social movement pushing the bill through. Without organized outside pressure, Waxman-Markey never made it out of the Senate. Contrast this with the subsequent success in 2022 of the IRA. The IRA’s journey to becoming law was long and tortured, but the core of its climate-related policies—which are by far the most significant climate laws the US has ever passed—remained intact through that journey. Sunrise and other groups like it were central to its passage.

All Politics Is Identity Politics

Whereas the NRA targeted its identity building on conservative rural white Christian men, Sunrise grows support by organizing across identity lines. One [pillar of its approach](#) ties the fight for climate justice to the fight for economic justice: “to stop climate change and create millions of good jobs in the process.” Another pillar ties the fight to antiracism: “to become the generation that turns the tide against racism and the institutions built upon it.” For Sunrise as for the NRA, effective politics is identity politics.

Of course, Harlon Carter and friends would scoff at the idea that they were involved in “identity politics.” But they’d be wrong. The term “identity politics” is [associated with the left](#), but Carter and the NRA built their movement by building a community. They cultivated ways for people to feel a sense of comradeship and belonging, signal their membership in the group, and relish every opportunity to “dunk” on all the anti-gunners outside it. The structures they built were the conditions that allowed an identity-based group to grow into a political juggernaut.

It's not only NRA members who dislike the term "identity politics." Across the political spectrum, people worry that it can seem exclusionary; creating an "us" also produces a "them." This appears to put identity politics at odds with messages like "we're all in it together" that have widespread appeal.

And of course, groupishness has a dark side too. After all, many of history's worst atrocities were perpetuated by groups exalting their own particular ethnic or religious identity while denigrating others. The Holocaust was one particularly horrifying installment in humankind's long, awful history of identity-based genocide and war. It spurred scientific interest in the psychology of identity, leading scholars to look into why people sort themselves so easily into opposing groups that end up hating and murdering each other.

One of the most alarming things scientists discovered was how ludicrously easy it is to coax people into an "us" versus "them" mentality. Research using what is called the "minimal group paradigm" shows that people start treating in-group members better than out-group members as soon as they have ways to tell the two groups apart. In one experiment, participants were told that a coin flip would put them on team A or B. Then they were given some money and told they could share it with other people in the experiment on either team. Participants were reliably more generous to people on their own team even though they knew the teams were assigned completely at random. Across studies, psychologists have had trouble finding anything that *can't* serve as a basis for groupishness, [from coin flips to T-shirt colors](#).

Put together, it's not surprising that people have doubts about identity politics. We're a little too susceptible to embracing arbitrary and irrational alliances, and those susceptibilities are a little too easy to exploit. If identities highlight our differences and make them exploitable, maybe they're something we should aspire to overcome. Wouldn't it be better if we set aside our differences and focused on common ground?

Not so fast. As we explored in chapter 6, the ability to coordinate and cooperate is one of our species' superpowers. As both the NRA and Sunrise make clear, that superpower is inextricably bound up in the psychology of groupishness, especially our gregariousness and craving for belonging. As much as people might want to "move beyond" it, the truth is that all politics is identity politics. [The movements that succeed](#) in making real change in the real world are anchored in a rich sense of who "we" are and what we stand for. Our groupishness remains a powerful pathway to making social change, for better or worse. Rather than lament it, we should continue exploring how to use it for good.

Still, it's one thing to understand that social identities are inseparable from community and belonging. It's another to figure out what leads people who identify with a group to participate in collective action. For every climate activist out in the streets, there's two more people proud to proclaim their staunch environmentalism . . . from the couch.

Fighting the Battle You Expect to Lose

What moves people from identity to action? An answer is beginning to take shape. One piece is perceiving—and feeling outraged by—injustice. Another is believing that you can do something about it.

It's one thing to feel affiliated with a group but it's another to witness something unfair happening to it. Recognizing and being affronted by injustice is key to [activating group identity](#). It's a big step to getting off the couch. A striking example is what often happens when politicians enact voting restrictions: they can fail to have their intended impact. While they may succeed in making it more difficult for some people to vote, they outrage and galvanize others. The effect on turnout can end up a wash.

It also helps when people really [think that they can make a difference](#). A person's sense of efficacy need not take the form of a grandiose belief that they, personally, can save the world. It can be motivating just to believe in their group's collective power. But what about those who don't believe their group can win? Pessimism often seems pretty reasonable and clear-eyed. When it comes to systemic change, the odds of success are long. Whether it's turning back the climate crisis or ending racial segregation, change is slow and piecemeal. If the motivation to work for change depends on the belief that one's group will win but winning seems desperately unlikely, what then? Does the will to fight require a delusion?

Maybe not. Consider Hong Kong's Umbrella Revolutionaries, who took action in the face of extreme risk and long odds. In 1997, when Great Britain's ninety-nine-year lease to govern Hong Kong was up, the area became a "special administrative region" of the People's Republic of China. Part of China's deal with Britain in the negotiations running up to the 1997 handover was that Hong Kong would be given a "high degree of autonomy" until at least 2047. The idea was "one country, two systems."

It didn't take long for China to blur the line. By 2003, Beijing began [flouting the terms of the agreement](#), in both spirit and letter. It tried to pass an anti-subversion law to criminalize speaking out in support of Hong Kong's secession. It stocked the election committee whose job was to choose the region's chief executive with loyalists to the mainland. In 2014, when Beijing nominally followed through on a promise to grant universal suffrage in Hong Kong, it added a last-minute proviso that candidates for office had to be picked by a nominating committee . . . controlled by China.

This sparked the Umbrella Revolution, so-called because pro-democracy protestors in Hong Kong used umbrellas to protect themselves from the police's use of tear gas, pepper spray, batons, and physical force. The protests kicked into a higher gear a few years later, in part due to the proposal of a new extradition law that would subject Hong Kong to China's criminal justice system, which authorized the arbitrary arrest of anyone who displeased the government.

A million people protested peacefully on June 9, 2019, followed by two million on June 12. In August of that year, there was a citywide strike, with protestors occupying the Hong Kong airport. The extradition bill was withdrawn in September, but the protests continued. The demographics of the protestors skewed young, pointing to a generational divide, but local elections in November 2019 vindicated the protestors' claims of widespread support. Record voter turnout [flipped all but one](#) of Hong Kong's eighteen district councils, granting overwhelming majority control to pro-democracy candidates.

Protestors in Hong Kong fought despite slim chances of victory, as did others protesting repression around the same time in Russia, Iran, and the countries of the Arab Spring. This is how it often goes for those challenging the status quo and seeking change, whether it's the NRA and the Federalist Society fighting their decades-long battle to reshape the American judiciary or Martin Luther King Jr. acknowledging that he might not reach the mountaintop. King's too-short life is an ominous reminder that the long, uncertain path toward progress is one few see to the end.

To better understand what motivates changemakers to persist in their efforts, social psychologist Arin Ayanian and colleagues surveyed large groups of people who had been active in protests in the 2010s in Russia, Ukraine, Hong Kong, and Turkey. These were places where it was manifestly risky to speak up and organize. The possibility of violent crackdowns was very real.

One thing Ayanian's team confirmed is that outrage is a clear spark to action. In Egypt, for example, the more outraged people felt over how protestors were being treated in the postcoup period after the fall of the Mubarak regime—and the more they [perceived themselves to be at risk](#)—the more likely they were to get involved. This is likely why some authoritarian regimes like Hungary's turn to subtle and insidious forms of repression. They don't want to trigger outrage.

A similar dynamic, [from repression to outrage to action](#), has shaped all kinds of nonviolent protest movements, from those in anti-apartheid South Africa to the Civil Rights Movement in the US. By responding to state violence with nonviolence—by turning the other cheek—activists in these movements gain the sympathy of those watching from the sidelines. Bystanders become outraged and join the fray.

A more surprising finding in Ayanian's research reveals how activists think of their own individual role in bringing about change in these high-risk contexts. They don't tend to think, "I, personally, have the power to make change." They don't even necessarily believe their group will prevail in the end. People who get involved in these movements are not usually self-deceived about the chances of success. They don't need to [trick themselves into having unrealistic confidence](#) in order to join the fight. Instead, Ayanian found that while activists were often doubtful that they or their movement would achieve all its aims, they felt they could make contributions *to the group*. As one Egyptian activist put it, "I do share part of my life, part of my thinking, part of my ideology with the people around me. . . . I wanted to redress the

injustice that was inflicted on us in this country. . . . We were all in this together . . . getting beaten in the same way . . . it was likely for any of us to lose his life for the sake of my goal, which is also his goal and all the protesters' goal. It kind of gives that sense of obligation. I didn't mind then to sacrifice my life for the sake of this goal. . . . It's kind of a shared thing between us."

This activist perspective upends a common way of thinking about what it means to make a difference. When high-risk activists are less sanguine about the prospects for achieving their highest aspirations—ending corruption or protecting human rights or winning the revolution—they remain optimistic about other things: sowing the seeds for future change by broadening national and international support, showing solidarity and love for the fellow activists they protest with, and, above all, building the group together. Although they don't think their movement can make all the difference, they think they can [make a difference to the movement](#).

Voting and Its Paradoxes

When Chris Field, who directs the Woods Institute for the Environment at Stanford, was interviewed about the most impactful things individuals can do for the environment, he didn't dwell on what people recycle or how much they fly. "[The most important thing anybody can do](#)," he said, "is to vote for a climate-friendly government agenda." For Field and so many other citizens of democracies, voting is the first thing that comes to mind when they think about their individual power to make a difference.

It's ironic that some people's sense of efficacy is so closely connected to their electoral power because voting is the standard example many philosophers and social scientists use to illustrate individual powerlessness. Given how unlikely one person's vote is to swing an election, it's puzzling why anyone goes through the trouble of voting at all.

Individual votes *can* make a difference. In 1994, Wyoming Governor Mike Sullivan pulled a ping pong ball out of his own battered cowboy hat to determine the next member of the state House of Representatives. The ball read "Randall Luthi," who then proclaimed, "It is [democracy at its best](#)." Luthi had tied Independent Larry Call with 1,941 votes each. In the case of a tie, Wyoming state law mandates the drawing of lots. Had any one of those 3,882 total voters made a different pick, or had a single nonvoter cast a ballot: no ping pong balls required.

[Ties and one-vote wins do happen](#) in US elections, but hoo boy are they rare. Of course, the odds of any one person casting a pivotal vote in an election go down as the number of voters goes up.

So, we should expect that as elections get larger and the chances that any single vote will swing the outcome shrink, citizens' participation will decline. The bigger the election, the less rational it appears for a person to pay the cost of voting, to bother with the hassle. People still turn out, though, giving rise to what has become known as [the Paradox of Voting](#).

In fact, the elections most Americans turn out for are the presidential ones, and these are *very* large. More than [154 million Americans](#) voted in the 2020 presidential election. The costs of voting in major elections can also be higher than usual, with some people having to navigate past serious obstacles to cast a ballot: restrictive laws, long lines, underfunded elections commissions, and intimidating fascists hovering around polling places. But even voters in the most frictionless system have to invest some effort or money to cast a ballot. When that ballot is just one out of tens of millions cast in an election, what's the point in pushing through such inconveniences, indignities, and injustices?

Despite all the complaints about low turnout and the exhortations people give each other to get to the polls, the Paradox of Voting is not about why such a small percentage of eligible voters actually vote. Rather, it's about why *anyone*, given the dramatically long odds of making a difference, [votes at all](#).

This is even more puzzling in light of how people routinely respond to odds in other parts of their lives. For the average American, the odds of getting in a car accident are 1 in 366 for every thousand miles driven. That's a much higher chance than casting the pivotal vote in an election. Seventy-seven percent of drivers get into at least one accident, and the [lifetime odds of dying](#) in these crashes are 1 in 107. These

odds go way up whenever drivers speed, text, drink alcohol, feel a little drowsy, or even just toggle the radio dial. The chances of something bad—potentially fatal!—happening in a car are alarmingly high. But those numbers still aren't high enough to change most people's behavior. Everybody keeps getting behind the wheel anyway.

Compare that to voting. A person is much, much less likely to cast a pivotal vote than to get in a car accident. But when it comes to voting, people are willing to change their behavior, disrupt their routines, and take on the costs and inconveniences of getting to the polls. Why do these [lower odds have a greater power](#) over what people do?

Whatever motivates people, it's not just odds and outcomes. What else gets people to the voting booth? Social identity. Maybe you vote because you're a Democrat, and voting gives you the feeling of belonging and contributing to the group. Or you do it because you're an American, and you believe voting is part of what it is to be a good American. Maybe you vote because you're a citizen and want to live up to all the democratic privileges and duties that citizenship entails. You vote, in other words, because *you're a voter*.

Research indeed finds that activating people's social identities can mobilize action and boost turnout—even if the identity is something as minimal as “voter.” One of the most effective nudges for getting people to vote is simply asking them, “[Are you going to vote?](#)” right before an election. This primes people to make their actions consistent with their words, to live up to their sense of themselves as the kind of person who votes.

Recall that the single best predictor of when people quit smoking is when their family and friends start quitting, and the best predictor of when people get solar panels is when their neighbors do. Voting works the same way. [We vote when our friends do](#). We also vote to keep up our reputation. One study emailed people to tell them that lists of eligible voters who stayed home in an election would be printed by the local newspaper. The threat of public shame increased voter turnout.

And here again, we're not just susceptible to social influence but also purveyors of it. It's easy to think of casting a vote solely in terms of its direct impact on the final tally; every vote is just one more ballot in the box. It's the same mistake that's so easy to make about recycling, thinking that any one person's impact is measured only by the number of jars and cans they toss in the blue bin. But as we've seen, individual actions, like recycling and putting solar panels on your house—and voting!—have social consequences, too.

Even in the seemingly solitary act of voting, we're all part of each other's situations, creating the context and shaping the norms that influence each other's decisions. By voting, and making it known that we did—it's what that “I Voted!” sticker is for, after all—we can normalize civic participation, multiply the impact of our actions, affect our friends' choices, and, from there, their friend's choices. There's more to the casting of a vote than its direct impact on the tally. The Paradox of Voting arises from the theoretical difficulty of understanding why anybody votes at all. Social identity and social influence are a big part of the answer. Record numbers of Americans voted in the 2020 presidential election, representing 67 percent of eligible voters.

But that still leaves a whopping [80 million who could have voted](#) and didn't. What motivates *them*? Many reported not being interested in politics, not feeling well-enough informed, not liking any of the available candidates, and—maybe you guessed it—not feeling like their vote will matter. Fifty percent of nonvoters believed that “I'm only one person, so my vote doesn't make a difference.” (Only 17 percent of voters felt the same.)

People can have lots of good reasons for not voting. We've already noted how many would-be voters face obstacles like intimidation, confusing ballots, and long lines in the cold November rain. But despite the prevalence of these voter suppression tactics, and even though the 2020 election occurred in the midst of an unprecedented global pandemic, the overwhelming majority of nonvoters [did not cite the difficulty of voting](#) or concerns about COVID-19 in their decision. A full 75 percent of them said voting was easy. The reason they didn't bother to vote was because it seemed futile.

When do nonvoters become voters? Perhaps when they see the choice to vote in terms of their identities,

tied to their need to belong and their commitment to support their communities. For some people, the most motivating ties may be to their friends and family, while for others, they may be to the community at large and the norms of civic engagement that sustain it. Nonvoters might find that voting just makes them feel good too. For Michael, the community vibe in the local elementary school is never better than on Election Day. He never feels closer to the stern old church ladies who check the precinct rolls.

Once the ball gets rolling, people might find that strengthening their connections to community, and doing things like voting as a result, spills over into further changemaking choices down the line. They might even come to be suspicious—as the three of us have—of the whole misleading, incomplete, overly individualist way of thinking about actions as isolated and independent and only adding up in discrete little increments. Maybe they could use some stern old church ladies in their lives.

Oxygen and Kindling: The Structural Background for Effective Collective Action

People crave belonging. It's a craving only satisfied by collective identity. But people can't have a collective identity all by their lonesome. It requires others too, a whole group of people connecting and being there for each other. These are more of the structural conditions that facilitate social movements and change. The craving, the community, the connection, the collective identity—these are the oxygen and kindling, the fuel that feeds the fire as it burns.

The big social movements and small personal choices we've explored in this chapter all take place against a huge array of structural background conditions. The NRA's rise and resilience took more than ginning up identity-based thinking in *American Rifleman* and offering its members life insurance. Its persuasive appeal can only be understood in cultural context. The motto "the only thing that stops a bad guy with a gun is a good guy with a gun" is blatantly false, but it is also an infuriatingly effective appeal to people awash in films, news, religions, and video games championing self-reliance and personal responsibility.

It's much the same background culture of individualism that made "people can stop pollution" and "we fear the jaywalker" and Candace Lightner's campaign against reckless drunk drivers so effective. Nowhere in the US is gun ownership and gun-owner identity as pervasive as in the South, where ideals of self-reliance are especially strong. Alongside these is the idea that [violence is an acceptable way](#) to settle conflicts. ("Violence as an acceptable means of settling conflicts"; see Harlon Carter.)

Beyond cultural factors, the NRA's success has been supported by explicit procedural features of the federal government. Gun control legislation is difficult to get through a US Senate that still honors the filibuster. With the filibuster, major legislative bills require 60 out of 100 Senators to support them. [Without the filibuster](#), simple congressional majorities could send gun regulations straight to the president's desk. The US government is replete with these kinds of "veto points." Their effect is to make it much easier to stifle change than to carry it through. Changing the status quo is far from a fair fight.

As a result, ushering in progressive social change is never going to be as simple as xeroxing the NRA's playbook. They've blocked gun regulations by microtargeting and activating a comparatively small group of highly motivated voters. Publicizing how vastly they're outnumbered will help the efforts to push past them. While all politics is identity politics, the more identities in the mix the better.

Building the Blaze: Coalitional Politics for Interdependent Individuals

Coalitions and Compromises

The spark is lit. You're outraged, think somebody should do something, and ready for that somebody to be you. Long as the odds may be, you're invested in transformative change and want to do the work. But you and what army?

The groups you're in—your friends, your tenant association, your fellow climate activists, even your political party—can't do it alone. More people need to get involved. That's true whether you're organizing to end the carceral state or persuading your company to divest from fossil fuels. No matter your ambition, you need buy-in. And it's virtually unavoidable that many of those stakeholders will have deep disagreements. If you're working on fossil fuel divestment, you've got to deal with the fact that some of your much-needed allies couldn't care less about rising sea levels, wildfires, and the extinction of polar bears. But they like a good return on their 401(k). Can you get them on board?

Changing structures requires coalitions of diverse people acting *somewhat* cooperatively. The New Deal of the 1930s brought about massive structural changes that radically reshaped American government and culture, so much so that historians sometimes refer to it as the “[third American revolution](#).” This third revolution was particularly remarkable because unlike the first two—the American Revolution and the Civil War—it didn't involve military conflict. But it certainly involved struggle.

Among other things, passing the package of laws and reforms that made up the New Deal required historically antagonistic factions on the left to form uneasy alliances. For example, in the US at the beginning of the 1930s, the Communist Party and the Congress of Industrial Organizations (the CIO, a leading federation of unions) were virtually at war. Their tentative and very short-lived willingness to work together in support of President Roosevelt's agenda helped secure its passage. It also broadened Roosevelt's mandate, leading to the passage of the National Labor Relations, Social Security, and Fair Labor Standards acts. These became known as the “Second New Deal.” Meanwhile, both the Communist Party and the CIO grew in membership and influence.

American Communists wanted far “deeper” structural changes than did the CIO and most other rank-and-file Democrats. The former's hesitation to join the union coalition reflected a reluctance to compromise on their more revolutionary agenda, which was basically to burn the system down rather than reform it from within. The groups ended up putting aside their differences temporarily, but the tension between mainstream and more radical flanks of the American left never disappeared.

Progressives and socialists' visions of change conflict in profound ways with those of [moderates](#) and “[popularists](#).” The latter emphasize that politics is “the art of the possible” and worry that more radical sides of the coalition are an electoral liability. Predictably, these disagreements are often framed in individual versus structural terms: a supposed competition between narrower reforms, which are portrayed as making modest improvements to individuals' lives, versus more sweeping, structural transformations.

During debates about marriage equality in the 1990s and 2000s, advocates wanted to extend the individual rights and privileges of marriage to LGBTQ people. Others rejected the focus on individual rights and wanted to challenge the entire institution of state-sponsored marriage. Likewise, during debates over Obamacare, supporters pointed to the millions of individual people who would become newly eligible for health insurance because of the ACA. Progressive critics worried that the bill would merely prop up a failing employer-based corporatized healthcare system. Again, they wanted to rebuild a new system from the ground up.

These debates seem to force an unhappy choice: someone interested in progressive change can either compromise and end up a centrist normie or refuse to compromise and become a hopeless revolutionary, shouting into the wind. Elements of this conflict may be unavoidable in some cases, but just as the alliance between the Communists and the CIO benefited both organizations, coalitional politics can create synergies between groups, too.

DREAMing of Multiethnic Democracy

In the early 2010s, in California, a group of college-aged kids who had been brought to the US as children decided to push back against the stigma of being “undocumented immigrants.” They were part of the group that came to be known as DREAMers. Sociologist Veronica Terriquez documented one of their efforts, around what they called the “[Coming out of the Shadows](#)” initiative. Terriquez tells how these California DREAMers “publicly declared their undocumented status in order to combat the stigma associated with their precarious legal situation and humanize their experiences in the eyes of broader audiences.”

They were inspired by the realization that many of them belonged to several different marginalized groups at once. Some DREAMers were dark-skinned; others were queer. This realization drove them to take a closer look at their intersecting and overlapping identities. Despite the obstacles to coming out—whether as undocumented or queer or both—many DREAMers did anyway. One student put it to Terriquez this way:

It wasn’t always okay to say that you were undocumented, but I guess when I first started college it was taboo, completely. I think now it’s okay to say, “I’m undocumented . . .” For me, I first got comfortable saying that I’m undocumented before I started saying “I’m queer” or “I’m gay” or “I’m LGBTQ.” I guess once you go through saying you’re undocumented, it’s easy to accept a queer identity and be able to talk about it with other people. Maybe it’s because you already have this sense of self-empowerment based on your undocumented status, that you can use that for your queer identity.

Terriquez refers to this as a kind of reverberating *social movement spillover*. It’s a positive feedback loop: “strategies originated by movement A are borrowed by movement B in pursuit of separate goals; yet in employing that strategy, movement B ends up furthering the aims of movement A.” In this case, activists for undocumented migrants borrowed ideas originating in queer activism. Then, the empowerment that queer DREAMers achieved by coming out as undocumented in turn strengthened their resolve to come out as queer.

This positive feedback loop between migrant and queer social movements didn’t just occur at the level of ideas and messaging. And it wasn’t just about helping individuals come out while leaving the structural status quo in place. Instead, activists built social movement spillover into the structural DNA of their organizations.

LGBTQ organizations created Queer Dream Summer, which set up internships for undocumented queer youth in LGBTQ organizations. Meanwhile, immigration groups created the Queer Undocumented Immigrant Project, whose policies aimed at promoting LGBTQ leadership within their ranks. Immigration groups also organized local workshops, on campuses and in local communities, to introduce straight movement members to the experiences of their queer-identified peers.

It’s tempting to assume that building a coalition requires setting differences aside. In that case, one would expect all this attention to the diverging experiences of people within larger movements to divide activists. But it didn’t. It had the opposite effect, creating a positive feedback loop of mutually reinforcing empowerment and connection. According to Terriquez’s research, more and more people began seeing commonalities between “[living in the shadows](#) and living in the closet.” And examples of social movement spillover like the queer DREAMers’—and [there are many more](#)—suggest that coalition builders can be

ambitious. They can lend and borrow ideas and strategies, like the empowering coming-out narrative. They can seek out ways to build intergroup collaboration into the basic nuts and bolts of their organizations. In the best of cases, seemingly separate social movements can push each other past a threshold and become bigger and bolder than they were before.

Race-Class Academy

Even when groups come together, others get cut out. The justly celebrated New Deal was the fruit not just of leftist coalitions but also of notorious exclusions. Roosevelt needed the support of white Southern Democrats to pass legislation, and he and the New Deal coalition made Faustian bargains to get it.

Black Americans were systematically excluded from receiving the benefits of many New Deal programs. For example, agricultural and domestic workers—who “coincidentally” tended to be Black and concentrated in the South—were [excluded from the Social Security Act](#), meaning the federal government would not provide these workers with pensions in their old age. Legislative compromises like this pitted the Black and white working class against each other. Roosevelt even refused to consider federal anti-lynching legislation, fearing it would endanger his coalition. The third American revolution, among the broadest progressive restructurings in US history, was [achieved on the backs of Black people](#).

Where does this leave present-day coalitional politics? If the left emphasizes “kitchen table” issues like providing good middle-class jobs, does it have to stay quiet about hot button social issues like racism and transphobia? Are the coalition-building tactics of the New Deal—which bridge divides between some marginalized groups only to exclude others—the only way forward?

We don’t think so. Just as Terriquez’s DREAMers found ways to form powerful coalitions between migrants and LGBTQ youth, there are ways to forge ties between the movement against racism and the movement against the evisceration of American workers. A promising path toward forging these ties goes through what law professor Ian Haney-Lopez calls [the “race-class narrative.”](#) For our money, it’s some of the best political both/and thinking around. And it holds general lessons for building coalitions and positive social movement spillover.

Haney-Lopez worked for many years as the cochair of the Advisory Council on Racial and Economic Justice at the AFL-CIO. (That’s the same CIO involved in the New Deal; since 1955, it’s been a huge part of the largest federation of unions in the US.) While there, Haney-Lopez conducted thousands of interviews, focus groups, and surveys with the aim of figuring out how people and politicians think and talk about race, class, and their intersection. He separated out three common approaches, studying how each one appealed—or didn’t—to different groups of voters. He also sought to devise a fourth messaging strategy that combined the strengths of the other three while avoiding their weaknesses.

First is what Haney-Lopez called “dog whistle” politics. Blowing into a dog whistle makes a sound that dogs can hear but humans cannot. Similarly, politicians often hint at race in oblique ways. They use nonracial terms that can seem innocuous and even appealing to outsiders but carry a coded meaning understood by those in the know. A politician might use the expression “people on welfare” as a thinly veiled way to criticize Black people. When then candidate Donald Trump accused Hillary Clinton of “meet[ing] in secret with international banks to plot the destruction of US Sovereignty,” he was dog whistling to antisemitic people. Dog whistling gives politicians and others [a flimsy kind of deniability](#), allowing them to point to the literal meaning of their words so that they don’t have to stand behind the message they’re actually conveying.

Second is the “call them bigots” approach, more popular among many liberals and leftists. The idea is to raise alarms about racism explicitly, whenever and wherever it’s found. It’s not hard to imagine why this approach is appealing. When someone like Trump launches into yet another racist rant, how could one *not* call it out?

The problem is that calling people bigots often plays right into the dog whistlers’ hands. When they’re charged with being racist, dog whistlers point to the literal meaning of their superficially nonracist words to “counterpunch.” They deny that racism had anything to do with it and then accuse their accusers: “I’m

not racist. You're racist for calling me—and my supporters—racist!" It's basically elevated "I'm rubber and you're glue" into one of the most consistently impactful political tactics since the mid-twentieth century.

Neither we nor Haney-Lopez think calling out racism is always counterproductive. But it's risky. It sets up the "who me? racist?" counterpunch, and it can also set off spirals of accusations. "[When people are called bigots](#) for beliefs that they view as common sense, they react badly," says Haney-Lopez, "insisting they are not racist, and then expressing outrage that anyone would suggest otherwise."

On top of all this, calling people out seems sometimes more about making yourself feel good than about building transformative social change. No doubt it can be satisfying to chew someone out, and occasionally it might help bolster solidarity. But it [can alienate potential allies](#).

The third approach Haney-Lopez studies takes the opposite tack: pretend race doesn't exist. Be "colorblind." Transcend our differences. This is among the most popular messages in politics, both in the US and most everywhere else, as versions of it appeal to voters from lots of different backgrounds. It seems like a straightforward way to get beyond racism. Forget about skin color and other arbitrary ways of putting people into boxes. Stop fixating on differences. Unite!

Reacting to the pitfalls of the "call them bigots" approach, defenders of this "ignore race" approach argue that honest conversations about racism are just too difficult and risky. Depressing as it may be, these conversations can be off-putting, they say, especially for white people. Their idea is to talk up issues that affect everyone instead, like good jobs and affordable healthcare. This crowd advocates prioritizing class over race.

Haney-Lopez found that this approach resonates more strongly with lots of people than "call them bigots." Many voters prefer political candidates and messages who appeal to universalistic values and policies, without mentioning race at all. But here's the big catch: Haney-Lopez found that the "avoid race" approach resonates *less* with voters than dog whistling, especially when it comes to drumming up support from moderate and conservative white people. Pretending racism is not the issue is a less effective political strategy than exploiting racist tropes.

The core takeaway from Haney-Lopez's "Race-Class Academy" is to reorient discussions of racism so that they focus on how "politicians promote racial conflict as a strategy to divide and distract people so they can get and hold onto power." This strategy doesn't shy away from talking about racism. But it holds that we should be talking about *strategic racism* rather than what one might think of as "personal" racism. Politicians, whatever their personal views about race, often use racism for their own political ends, strategically stoking division to gain power and block progressive change. That's what we should be talking about, Haney-Lopez argues.

The race-class narrative has three steps: "distrust powerful elites stoking division," "join together across racial lines," and then "demand government for all." Here's what that looks like in practice, broken down into key elements, with [explanations from Haney-Lopez's team](#) in italics:

No matter where we come from or what our color, most of us work hard for our families. *The aim here is to discuss racism explicitly and to make clear that it affects everyone.*

But today, certain politicians and their greedy lobbyists hurt everyone by handing kickbacks to the rich, defunding our schools, and threatening our seniors with cuts to Medicare and Social Security. Then they turn around and point the finger for our hard times at poor families, Black people, and new immigrants. *This message depicts racial scapegoating as something that harms all kinds of people economically.*

We need to join together with people from all walks of life to fight for our future, just like we won better wages, safer workplaces, and civil rights in our past. *The message evokes a sense of collective fate and previously successful cross-racial movements.*

By joining together, we can elect new leaders who work for all of us, not just the wealthy few. *Finally, the message focuses on what people need to do.*

To the extent that Haney-Lopez's approach recommends openly confronting racism (step 1) and building an interracial coalition to overcome it (step 2), it bears little resemblance to approaches that ignore race and focus on kitchen table economic concerns alone. But the last step of the race-class narrative—demanding government for all—is just as important. The narrative shares the end goal of making structural changes that benefit everyone: universal healthcare, pre-K, clean air, and so on.

Building coalitions greater than the sum of their parts means going through race and identity, not bypassing them. This requires both acknowledging differences and finding ways to harmonize them. Consider the fight against climate change. It doesn't affect us all equally—it hits communities marginalized by poverty and prejudice the worst—but it does affect us all.

There aren't any magic solutions in politics, of course. Nobody knows just [how effective and broadly appealing](#) Haney-Lopez's approach can be. But more and more political actors are following his lead. The proposed Green New Deal, and its descendants the Build Back Better plan and the IRA, are testaments to this approach's potential. They achieved a critical mass of grassroots and legislative backing by yoking the fight against the climate crisis to the fights for economic and racial justice. More and more researchers are studying similar tactics.

One series of studies, for example, found that when African and Asian Americans reflect on the history of laws prohibiting interracial marriage, they [become more supportive of gay marriage](#). As John Lewis, a 1960s civil rights leader turned US Representative, explained in 2014, "I fought too hard and too long against discrimination based on race and color not to stand up—and speak up—against discrimination against our gay and lesbian brothers and sisters. I see the right to marry as a civil rights issue." Framing gay marriage as a matter of civil rights, continuous with antiracist struggles, highlights the joint importance of our distinctive identities and shared fates. This, in short, is how one social movement spills over into another.

Building Up an Intersectional Mindset

The race-class narrative provides a template for talking about the distinctive struggles that members of oppressed groups face and the role that racism, sexism, and other forms of prejudice and discrimination play in their oppression—while at the same time seeking out points of common ground around which coalitions can be built.

But Haney-Lopez wasn't the first person on the both/and beat. [Black American feminists](#) like Anna Julia Cooper, Sojourner Truth, and Maria Stewart, together with oppressed women of color the world over, have been pushing back against zero-sum, either/or thinking since at least the 1800s. Feminists of color have roundly criticized the idea that advancing one important political aim (like racial justice) must come at the expense of advancing others (like gender, class, or environmental justice). In bell hooks's words, "Whenever we love justice and stand on the side of justice we refuse simplistic binaries. We refuse to allow either/or thinking to cloud our judgment. We embrace the logic of both/and. We acknowledge the limits of what we know."

hooks and others sought to see and interact with the world *intersectionally*. The intersectional approach involves a certain way of engaging with the social world and building coalitions to change it. It's an approach exemplified by Terriquer's California DREAMers and queer activists. Without denying the differences in their struggles, they saw opportunities for connection.

The term "intersectionality" dates to 1989, when Kimberlé Crenshaw—building on decades of work by feminists of color like hooks—used it to show how social identities overlap and "intersect" to produce unique kinds of oppression. Black women, readers will be shocked to learn, are both Black people and women. They face many forms of prejudice and discrimination, some of which are shared with other women and people of color. But they face distinctive obstacles, too.

For example, recall a 2023 finding on racial disparities in maternal and infant health, which we first

cited in chapter 3. Rich Black women and their children have worse outcomes than poor white women and their children, even in a wealthy, well-funded, liberal state like California: “For every 100,000 births, 173 of the babies born to the richest white mothers die before their first birthday. 350 babies born to the poorest white mothers die. 437 babies born to the richest Black mothers die. 653 babies born to the poorest Black mothers die.” For poor Black infants to be nearly four times more likely to die than rich white infants is simply unconscionable. Economist Maya Rossin-Slater concludes that the problems Black children and child bearers face are “much more structural” than just addressing poverty, healthcare, racism, or sexism in isolation.

Despite this, “intersectionality” is among the most controversial of buzzwords. It’s criticized as divisive by the colorblind universalists who urge “avoiding race.” It’s cast by right-wing ideologues as a “conspiracy theory of victimization” and a “new caste system” that places non-white, nonheterosexual people at the top.

These criticisms badly misrepresent the intersectional tradition. As Deborah King explains,

in addressing the National Association for the Advancement of Colored People (NAACP) Legal Defense Fund in 1971, Fannie Lou Hamer, the daughter of sharecroppers and a civil rights activist in Mississippi, commented on the special plight and role of black women over 350 years: “You know I work for the liberation of all people because when I liberate myself, I’m liberating other people . . . her [the white woman’s] freedom is shackled in chains to mine, and she realizes for the first time that she is not free until I am free.” *The necessity of addressing all oppressions is one of the hallmarks of black feminist thought.*

Addressing all oppressions isn’t easy. Black feminists have, since at least the 1800s, decried how feminist groups neglect race, how antiracist groups neglect gender, and how both neglect class. And the same labor groups that made ideas like “class solidarity” salient in American minds were notorious for excluding women and non-white workers. Robin Zheng describes an interview the labor organizer Jane McAlevey gave alongside the organizer of the first national Women’s March after the election of Donald Trump:

[McAlevey] pointed out that numerically the largest organizations of women in the country are trade unions, and that unions are the primary defenders of working-class women’s workplace rights. When asked whether the Women’s March would demand a mass expansion of trade unions, however, the organizer replied: “That’s actually not my topic.” McAlevey goes on to declare: “The idea that it’s ‘not my issue’ is what is wrong with the so-called progressive movement in this country.”

This “not my issue” approach is exactly what intersectionality opposes. It threatens to feed right into a self-undermining, either/or, zero-sum mentality that fosters division, as each group is liable to see others’ gains as their own losses.

Crenshaw pushes back against this mistake when she says that intersectionality is “basically a lens, a prism, for seeing the way in which various forms of inequality often operate together and exacerbate each other.” It’s more a mindset than a method. Part of the goal is to take seemingly separate movements and find ways to say, “We have our movement, and we support yours.”

Adopting an intersectional mindset requires keeping two thoughts in mind: people’s social identities and experiences make them different from one another in important ways, *and yet* in virtue of living in unjustly stratified societies, people’s identities are also a rich source of connection and coalition. It involves remaining aware of all the different social categories, all the different boxes people put each other in, while appreciating how all the boxes are interrelated.

Researchers who study what they call “intersectional awareness” find that it’s intimately tied to other

structure-facing skills, traits, and habits of attention. **People with an intersectional mindset** are more open to new experiences and more willing to adopt others' perspectives. They're more likely to see big-picture political problems as personally relevant to their lives. They value diversity, are less prejudiced toward other groups, and are not afraid to interrupt discrimination when they find it. They're more likely to recognize that the status quo is unjust, and they're more motivated to change it. The more people think in intersectional ways, the more eager they are to engage in collective action.

Intersectional awareness is "a way of thinking about the world that anyone can practice," even white men like the authors of this book. We can learn to better appreciate the ways that our experiences of whiteness are shaped by our experiences of being men, and vice versa. Pretty much everyone has reason to adopt an intersectional mindset, whether they're privileged or oppressed. Doing so helps each of us, regardless of our social identities, better understand the structural injustices that shape our lives, so as to end them.

Facing the Fire: Understanding the Social World in a Both/And Way

Strivers

To build winning coalitions, we need to learn to see the structural obstacles holding people back. One person who's done wonders helping others see hidden structures is the philosopher Jennifer Morton, whose focus is on obstacles in higher education. Morton taught for years at the City College of New York, working with hundreds of first-generation college [students whom she calls "strivers."](#) These are students from working-class backgrounds, often children of immigrants. They're in college to achieve the American Dream. When people describe education as the engine of upward mobility, strivers are often who they have in mind.

Morton herself was a striver but one with an unusual opportunity to peek over the fence and see what wealth and opportunity looked like. As she explains in an interview, "I grew up in Lima, Peru. My mom got pregnant with me when she was 17. Peru in the '80s was beset by terrorism, high inflation, political instability. I mostly grew up with my grandmother, but I also had a wealthy aunt . . . I grew up . . . having a working-class family life and then going to school with extremely wealthy people, some of whom were the children of the prime minister or owners of big companies in our country. And so it was very strange. I grew up straddling these two worlds."

Teachers, administrators, policymakers, voters, and sometimes strivers themselves think that what these students most need to succeed is individual grit and gumption. The message they get is that the path out of poverty is really difficult, but if you give it your all, then you can push through. In economic terms alone, this message is basically right. College graduates tend to make about [\\$1.2 million more](#) over their lifetime than people who only hold a high school diploma.

But one problem with this message is that strivers rarely have a full picture of the obstacles that make the path out of poverty so difficult. It's not just that they have to study hard and avoid distractions. Many also have to balance schoolwork and a long commute to campus with full-time employment, often at multiple jobs. Professors can be oblivious or indifferent, and bosses can be inflexible. On top of all that, their families might expect them to be available to take care of siblings or elders. Lots of strivers have kids of their own too. They're straddling separate worlds.

Strivers also have the burden of needing to learn new norms at school. From music to clothes to food, [college can be an exhausting, alien world](#). And even once they've learned its unfamiliar ways, they're torn about following them. It can feel like selling out, betraying their past, and losing their authentic selves. Their high school friends won't hesitate to get on their case about putting on airs and forgetting where they came from.

So, one problem Morton points out is that strivers and their families rarely get the whole story about what college demands. [The three of us also work at large public universities](#) committed to serving strivers, and we've watched many struggle. The success-through-relentless-grit narrative leaves out a big part of what the experience is really like. Too many students are under the impression that it's on them as individuals to juggle it all by themselves: school, work, commuting, caretaking, homemaking, learning new norms, and holding onto old ones. When strivers are unable to thrive on all these fronts simultaneously, they often think they're the problem. Those who stick with it resolve to just suck it up, work harder, sleep less.

Yet the message that strivers just need to work harder obscures what Morton describes as a genuine ethical dilemma. The economic benefit of a college degree is undeniable, but there's more to life than

money. Morton remembers what it was like leaving Lima to carve out her own path in the US: “I was extremely close to [my grandmother] growing up. I mean, for me, she was the world. And now to not be able to be as close to her, it’s a very painful cost.” Moving up, she realized, meant moving *out*. She wasn’t just straddling different worlds but also had to choose between them. To go to college in the US, she had to leave behind relationships, her hometown, her whole familiar sense of self. That’s not an easy choice. And it’s a choice that students from privileged backgrounds don’t usually have to make.

One option for strivers facing this dilemma is to throw themselves headlong into college even if it means being less available to family and old friends. The appeal of this option is real. College can launch strivers into satisfying careers, giving them opportunities to pursue a calling rather than just some job that pays the bills.

The other option is to quit school. Many take it—first-generation students are [less likely to finish college](#)—and then have to deal with the stigma of being dropouts. Morton reframes the option, though, showing that many of those who decide to leave college are making a rational, caring, ethical choice. Feeling forced to choose, they choose friends, family, and community.

Striving for Better Options

Both gritting it out in college and returning home incur real costs for strivers. But maybe those aren’t the only two options. Once strivers, and the rest of us, get a better view of the structural constraints they’re operating within, we can start to ask whether those barriers can be torn down. Maybe it’s time to reject this unfair either/or choice and demand better.

There’s a lot that individuals and schools can do to ease strivers’ dilemma. Professors can be more aware of and sympathetic to their students’ situations and acknowledge and discuss their predicaments. For example, Alex assigns a podcast interview with Jen Morton at the beginning of his classes. Professors can also build flexibility into the structure of their courses so that students aren’t penalized when they have to cope with unexpected family demands.

Meanwhile, if family members better understand strivers’ challenges, they might start putting less unfair pressure on them. Maybe there are tweaks that schools can implement to help family members reframe their perspectives on strivers’ situations. Just as there’s a student orientation process for onboarding the incoming class, there could be a [family orientation process](#) to go along with it.

But it can’t just be up to teachers and families to change their expectations, as if in a vacuum. One reason strivers get called home to babysit is the dearth of affordable childcare. One reason they work long hours is that college is too expensive. They keep full-time jobs because they (and their families) need the income. The larger goal has to be creating a fair playing field via [further-reaching structural reforms](#): free tuition, affordable childcare, elder care for students and their families, smaller class sizes to help teachers stay attuned to individual students’ needs, and so on.

We shouldn’t treat the unjust structures that define higher education as fixed, nonnegotiable facts. They aren’t immutable conditions that strivers just have to accept. Black feminist [bell hooks argues](#) for coming to see the unjust structures as changeable:

Often, African Americans are among those students I teach from poor and working-class backgrounds who are most vocal about issues of class. They express frustration, anger, and sadness about the tensions and stress they experience trying to conform to acceptable white, middle-class behaviors in university settings while retaining the ability to “deal” at home. Sharing strategies for coping from my own experience, I encourage students to reject the notion that they must choose between experiences. They must believe they can inhabit comfortably two different worlds, but they must make each space one of comfort. They must creatively invent ways to cross borders. They must believe in their capacity to alter the bourgeois settings they enter. All too often, students from nonmaterially

privileged backgrounds assume a position of passivity . . . as though they can only be acted upon against their will. Ultimately, they end up feeling they can only reject or accept the norms imposed upon them. This either/or often sets them up for disappointment and failure.

hooks urges students to reject the choice between fitting in or leaving. Instead, she admires those who realize that the status quo is unjust and who respond by trying to upend it. She encourages students to think of themselves as agents of change, actively reshaping the structures they inhabit rather than passively accepting them.

Many do. There's no shortage of examples of [students turning this attitude into organized action](#). But what's less obvious is how they come to adopt this changemaking mindset in the first place. People often begin thinking of themselves as agents of change when they come to see the world as changeable. But how does that happen?

(Some of) the Kids Are All Right

Kids begin noticing the importance of status at a remarkably young age, but they don't all end up thinking about it the same way. Some come to think of the advantages that certain groups have over others as the natural way of things, while some come to see those advantages as unfair and changeable.

[By the time they're seven years old](#), American kids know that Black people typically have less money than white people and women often have lower-status jobs than men. Similar effects have been found in other countries. In Iran, seven- to twelve-year-old children perceive Iranian kids to be of lower status than their American counterparts. Kids all over the world have a surprising ability to soak up information about group-based inequalities. They also tend to place a lot of weight on language and accents. In India, kids ages five to ten think Indian-English speakers make for "worse leaders" than British-English speakers. In the US, ten-year-olds identify speakers with Southern accents as less "in charge" than those with Northern accents.

These are all examples of kids' "knowledge of social structures." When Iranian children tell researchers that American kids are of higher status than Iranian kids, they're communicating an awareness of how their social world works. Most (but as we'll see, not all) kids also assume that [where a group sits in a pecking order](#) reflects something internal to it, like that the group's members are inherently intelligent or assertive (rather than just being lucky inheritors of unearned privileges).

Part of the allure of these intuitive falsehoods about status is that many kids *like* the idea of hierarchy. That might sound ominous. Isn't equality the obvious ideal? But think about how fascinated people get with those at the top of different pecking orders: royalty, celebrities, athletes, billionaires.

That said, enthusiasm for hierarchy isn't universal. Some kids come to see social hierarchies as unfair. Some go on to put their lives on the line to overthrow them. When they do, it's usually [a result of what they were taught](#). Social psychologists repeatedly find that parents' attitudes toward hierarchy make a big difference to their kids. Parents who are structurally alert tend to have kids who are structurally alert too.

In one study, researchers divided preschoolers using the minimal group paradigm we described back in chapter 10. Decades of research show that people play favorites based on group identity even when the groupings are trivial. In this case, preschoolers were arbitrarily sorted into either a red or blue group and then given T-shirts and wristbands with matching colors. Next, they watched a video of a kid from their group (wearing the same shirt) who refused to share a candy bar with a kid from the other group. Later, the preschoolers were asked to give out paper coins to the two kids they saw in the video, the in-group member who refused to share or the out-group kid who got stiffed. How did the preschoolers distribute the coins? Would they give more to the in-group member, overlooking that blatant display of selfishness?

Some kids did show in-group favoritism, but some didn't. The preschoolers' choices were predicted by their *parents'* preferences for social hierarchy. Children with parents who dislike hierarchies penalized the

stingy in-group member by giving them fewer coins. Those with parents who like hierarchies didn't penalize the in-group member at all.

It looks like kids whose parents are suspicious of hierarchy have a head start on seeing social systems and grasping how they work. Figuring out how parents pass along these preferences is a work in progress. Some intentionally teach their kids about unfair status differences, but other kids likely absorb their parents' worldview through passive family osmosis. Either way, it's pretty clear that parents who are skeptical about hierarchy have children who share their skepticism.

Dreaming of Structures That Never Were and Asking Why Not

Another thing that stifles people's ability to see and understand social structures is that they're abstract and complex. This also makes imagining alternatives—including other, better ways the world could be structured—incredibly difficult. Social scientists call the general ability to do this “counterfactual reasoning.” It's the capacity to consider possibilities that might have been or may be in the future. How would a scenario have played out if earlier conditions had been different from—*counter* to—how they actually—in *fact*—were?

Sometimes history can help us think about how things might have unfolded differently. Writing about enslaved Americans and their descendants, [Isabel Wilkerson explains](#), “On those cotton fields were opera singers, jazz musicians, playwrights, novelists, surgeons, attorneys, accountants, professors, journalists. . . . We know that because that is what they and their children and now their grandchildren and even great-grandchildren have often chosen to become once they had the chance to choose for themselves.”

Other times, the only way to use counterfactual reasoning is through imagination. Would Superman still love “truth, justice, and the American way” if his spaceship had landed in [Moscow, Russia, instead of Smallville, Kansas](#)? If you think Superman's inner Kryptonian essence would make him inherently good no matter where he landed, you'll expect the story to go one way. But if you think the social systems he grew up with exert a strong influence, you might expect it to unfold differently. How you think about these imaginary scenarios reveals your underlying understanding of what caused what in the story.

Counterfactual reasoning is something we do all the time, but people differ in which kinds of possibilities come most readily to mind. Some people are liable to focus on others' inner characteristics and how they could be different. Maybe if that striver had had more grit, she wouldn't have dropped out of school. Others are liable to imagine leaving individuals as they are while considering how features of [their situation could be different](#). Maybe that striver wouldn't have dropped out if tuition had been more affordable.

The ability to entertain situational counterfactuals—to consider all the different ways that social structures could have been—is a distinctive kind of skill. Like other skills, it can be improved with practice. Imagine that someone named Jamal, who is Black, shows up late for work. His white coworkers don't know why. Maybe it was his fault (he absentmindedly forgot to set the alarm), or maybe there were factors beyond his control (bad traffic due to an accident). Because of cultural stereotypes about Black people, many coworkers leap to the conclusion that Jamal's laziness is to blame. But some of them lack that impulse to stereotype. They're in the habit of considering “situational” explanations first rather than individualist ones.

[Some studies have people practice](#) coming up with different kinds of explanations in scenarios like these. Instead of myopically fixating on what that one individual could have done differently to change his fate, participants can build up the skill of looking at how structures shape behavior. As they become less likely to blame people for the things that happen *to* them, they also start to show reduced racial bias. So just as Trish Devine said about prejudice, the individualist impulse to ignore social structures is a habit that can be broken.

Some structural conditions are more or less conducive to breaking these individualist habits. For white American kids to understand racial inequality, for example, they need information about it. But in too many ways, they're prevented from seeing what the lives of non-white people are actually like. They don't

have daily interactions with non-white kids because they live in different neighborhoods and attend segregated schools. As they grow up, their [media is shaped by cultural segregation](#), so they're likely to watch different TV shows while being fed different parts of the internet by social media algorithms. "Colorblind" parents who refuse to talk to their kids about race don't help either. Children who grow up in these types of conditions often enter professions marked by occupational segregation, working in spaces with few non-white people.

The upshot is that too often kids and the adults they become don't have enough real-world experience with people from other groups to understand how they end up where they do or what it's like to be there. This makes thinking about alternative explanations for why some groups stay stuck in disadvantaged circumstances that much harder.

There are both individual and structural improvements that can help us do better counterfactual thinking about injustice. Segregation makes it harder for people to notice and understand all the structural factors propping up racial inequity. It's yet one more reason segregation needs to go. But dismantling it is going to require changing attitudes toward segregation. And doing *that*, in turn, is going to involve people becoming more structure facing: learning about how segregation prevents us from noticing and understanding structural racism. Seeing structures as changeable, we'll be freed up to dream of antiracist worlds that never were and ask why not.

All in the Family of Structure-Facing Skills

Learning to reason counterfactually about how social structures affect us is one example of a broader family of [structure-facing skills](#) that are both useful and learnable. Here are a handful of others.

Resisting Status Quo Bias and System Justification

There is a powerful tendency to stand pat with "the devil that you know"; it's allegedly better than the devil you don't. But in an unjust world, this "status quo bias" is a weapon for blocking progressive change. Some of its forms are pretty intuitive. If you're wealthy and privileged, it's easy to assume that the world is a relatively just place because things are going well . . . for you.

But what's really striking about status quo bias is that people getting the short end of the stick exhibit it too. Those suffering the worst injustices of hierarchical social systems regularly get [duped into thinking the system is acceptable](#), even just. One reason is they're soaking up the same message that strivers get: rising up the ladder is just a matter of striving hard enough. Many people find comfort in thinking they have personal control over the shape of their own lives, whether they actually climb the ladder or not. It may be safer to think things aren't going well for you because you haven't tried hard enough than it is to think that things aren't going well for you because the system is unfair. At least in the first case, the outcome is up to you. But if you think that, then you're also likely to think that successful people got to where they are because they're naturally gifted or hustled their way to the top. They must deserve their status. Researchers call all this "system justification"—endorsing an unjust social status quo even when people are disadvantaged by it.

Being able to imagine alternative scenarios helps us to break free from status quo bias and system justification. Considering a wide range of different ways the world might operate can dislodge the impulse to roll with the default option. But much as we learned in previous chapters about lighting the spark, coming to realize that the status quo is unjust is just one step. Getting motivated to actually do something about it comes next.

Feeling Engaged Versus Being Engaged

Lots of people who get riled up about racial and environmental injustices never quite make it off the couch. They [treat politics like a hobby](#). Political hobbyism, as political scientist Eitan Hersh calls it, is the tendency to consume, discuss, and emote about politics with like-minded peers, often online. He argues

that this is a problem because hobbyists' engagement with politics and social change ends there. All that energy devoted to reading, arguing, or being outraged could be better spent doing things like attending community meetings, participating in political party committees, and recruiting and volunteering on behalf of state legislative candidates.

Hobbyism is a real problem in the United States, particularly for progressives. In survey research from 2018, Hersh finds that a third of respondents reported spending at least two hours a day consuming news and thinking about politics. Of these, virtually none reported spending even a trivial amount of time working or volunteering for any political organization. This disparity between hobbyist activities and time spent engaging in collective action was especially pronounced among well-educated white liberals.

Hersh's view is that hobbyism is a problem for well-educated white liberals because they don't personally have much at stake in the issues they're upset about. They're materially comfortable with the way things are even if they feel strongly about justice and politics. Hobbyism is another mark of status quo bias, in other words. And if Hersh's diagnosis is right, then it's not enough to just start paying attention to and getting upset by existing structural injustices. Structure-facing skill is about seeing all the problems out there, acknowledging the concrete ways you might be benefiting from them, and finding the pathways that *you*, an individual, can take to do something about them.

Humility and Flexibility

Humility, and the desire to be better, is a crucial element of structure-facing skill and both/and thinking. Again, the relationships between individuals and social structures are incredibly complex. Understanding how they contribute to social problems like racism and climate change and poverty is no easy task, nor is figuring out solutions. Predicting the effects of our efforts to tackle these kinds of problems is its own hornet's nest (see chapter 9).

On top of all this—the inherent complexity of social structures and systems and the difficulty of knowing how to change them—we're all constantly bombarded with messages from motivated actors purporting to boil problems down to simple solutions. "It's all because of Fox News!" "The solution is education!" "Real change comes from within." It's never that simple, of course, and a general sense of humility can help inoculate against the worst excesses of oversimplification, overconfidence, and hype.

It's more than a matter of personal humility. There's also [room for cultural humility](#), which is closely tied to the intersectional mindset we explored in the last chapter. The culturally humble tend to be interested in and accepting of how groups other than their own do things. They tend to seek out, rather than be uncomfortable with, unfamiliar people and places. Like other forms of humility, this cultural version is rooted in a learning-oriented mentality. It turns on the idea that one's understanding of others is incomplete.

Think again about segregation and how it obstructs structural change by obstructing our ability to notice oppressive structures. Resisting segregation—of one kind or another—is part of the solution, but individuals vary a lot in how interested, comfortable, and willing they are to spend time with and learn from people unlike themselves. Research from Italy has shown how cultural humility shapes people's willingness to try to overcome this barrier. The more culturally humble a research group of Italians was, the more they thought of contact with Muslim migrants as a positive thing.

[Overconfidence leads people](#) to hold on tight to what they think they already know. The antidote is "cognitive flexibility." People who are cognitively flexible are good at seeing things from multiple perspectives and imagining alternative possibilities. They uncover novel links between what they're learning and what they've already learned. Their minds change when the evidence changes, and they generate creative ways to solve problems. [Cognitive flexibility looks like it gets better](#) with practice as well.

Cognitively flexible people are also less likely to get suckered in by bullshit—specifically "[pseudo-profound bullshit](#)," to use psychologists' technical term. Examples of pseudo-profundity include "guidance is the nature of grace, and of us," "the goal of morphic resonance is to plant the seeds of ecstasy

rather than stagnation,” and “moisture is the essence of wetness.” (For all your own pseudo-profound bullshit needs, visit the generator at <http://sebpearce.com/bullshit/>.) Lots of people are easily duped into thinking nonsense like this is meaningful, deep, and true. But researchers find that those who enjoy the kind of careful and open-ended thinking required for cognitive flexibility are more suspicious of pseudo-profundity. They’re also less susceptible to bogus paranormal and conspiratorial theories, COVID-19 misperceptions, fake science, and political misinformation. They’re less confident about predicting the future and less likely to claim to know more than they do.

Whereas cognitively rigid thinkers might try to pin problems like racism and the climate crisis on a handful of bad-acting villains, the cognitively flexible are ready to see how vexed these “everything problems” are. These problems can’t be boiled down to a short list of faces and names. Their causes are distributed and dispersed, and their influence over our lives is subtle, statistically diffuse, and ubiquitous.

Seeing Where You Stand

Research suggests that [acknowledging one’s own racial privilege](#) encourages people to engage in collective action. In one study, researchers showed people videos of highly publicized racialized incidents: one from Yale University, in which a police officer demands to see a Black student’s ID, saying “we need to make sure you belong here,” and another from a Philadelphia Starbucks, in which the cops were called on a Black man who was doing nothing but waiting for his friends to arrive before ordering coffee.

Before showing them the videos, the researchers asked participants to fill out a scale measuring their awareness of racial privilege. They were asked to agree or disagree with statements like “White people have privileges that Black people do not have in the United States” and “White people are at an advantage because they hold most of the positions of power in American society.” There was a marked difference in how people responded to the videos, depending on how they responded to the “awareness of racial privilege” scale. After seeing the videos, it was the people who acknowledged their own privilege who were more interested in engaging in collective action to fight for racial justice. An awareness of the background structures of racial advantage and disadvantage is key to noticing and mobilizing against the concrete racial injustices right there in front of you, in the foreground.

From Sparking to Building to Seeing to Sustaining the Fire

Structure-facing skills push us to face the fire and sharpen our abilities to pay attention to social structures and understand how they work. Learning them is a both/and endeavor since it involves individual people coming to see how they’re connected to the systems that shape their world. Structure-facing skills are tools for directing our passions in the right way, especially once they’ve been ignited by group identities and enlarged through collaboration and coalition building.

And yet, all of this is still not enough. The goal isn’t just to make change. It’s to make *lasting* change.

Keeping the Fire Going: The Gloriously Unsexy Work of Implementing and Sustaining Change

Implementation: Where Good Ideas Go to Die

Starting social change is tough enough, but implementing and sustaining it might be even tougher. The work often takes place in what political scientist Leah Stokes calls the “fog of enactment.” It’s the nebulous gap between passing some big, new, complex policy and putting that policy into practice. The [fog of enactment](#) is where good ideas too often go to die once the light of public attention and activists’ interest falters. This chapter is about learning to navigate through the fog.

Even popular ideas get lost in the fog of enactment. In the 1980s, crime in American cities was bad and trust in the police was low. Reformers were dissatisfied with the emphasis at the time on responding to 911 calls one by one rather than addressing the root problems that led to them. One response came to be known as [“community policing.”](#)

The idea was to restore a connection between law enforcement and the communities they’re supposed to serve. In some ways, community policing was a throwback to the days when officers walked their beats and made house calls. It’s an amorphous idea but has a few core tenets. First is decentralization. Police officers are assigned to specific neighborhoods to foster communication and trust between them and the community. Solutions grounded in the local community’s concrete needs are prioritized over top-down decisions.

A second tenet is community engagement. Departments are encouraged to share information with communities about the problems they see and what they’re doing about them. Officers are encouraged to take a less adversarial stance toward citizens, participating in organized meetings where they can listen to members of the community and come to understand their concerns.

This is closely tied to a third tenet: problem-solving. Rather than preparing for splashy but low frequency events like high-speed car chases after fleeing bank robbers, community policing teaches departments to focus on the day-to-day problems affecting people’s lives. Over time, this broadens the scope of police responsibility. If the community is fed up with rats, loud parties, and derelict buildings, community-engaged police can’t say “not our problem.” Rats, noise, and falling-down buildings become police problems.

Together, these innovations comprised the most important developments in policing in the last quarter of the twentieth century. By 2015, [nearly every US city](#) with more than 250,000 people named community policing as a policy priority.

It’s no surprise, then, that political scientists, criminologists, and public policymakers wanted to know whether community policing works. Sometimes it seems to. Notable successes, like Chicago’s Alternative Policing Strategy, were associated with improved relations between police and residents, more involvement of residents in decision-making, and stronger approval of law enforcement. But larger scientific reviews of community policing have been mixed. Some found that community policing reduced crime, while others [found null results](#).

In 2021, a team of twenty-six researchers—mostly political scientists—published a paper in the journal *Science* reporting their attempts to get a better view of whether, when, and how community policing works. Their project took “robust methodology” to a whole new level. The team ran a randomized control trial of community policing in [six different countries](#): Brazil, Colombia, Liberia, the Philippines, Uganda,

and Pakistan. Some “treatment areas” were rural, like in Uganda, while others were urban, like in Medellín, Colombia. The program was administered by the local police in a total of 707 neighborhoods, districts, and villages, covering roughly nine million people.

Four elements of community policing were implemented: foot patrols, town halls, community meetings, and problem-oriented policing. The effects of these programs were compared to carefully matched control areas, where existing policing practices were left in place. In total, 18,382 citizens were interviewed, along with 874 police officers, and crime data from the treatment areas was analyzed.

Here’s how Graeme Blair and his twenty-five colleagues [summarize their mega-study’s findings](#): “Increases in locally appropriate community policing practices led to no improvements in citizen-police trust, no greater citizen cooperation with the police, and no reduction in crime in any of the six sites. . . . Although citizens reported more frequent and robust exposure to the police in places where community policing was implemented, we have limited evidence of police action in response to citizen reports.”

If you listen closely, you can almost hear all twenty-six researchers cursing in unison.

What went wrong? The problem wasn’t that citizens refused to cooperate with the police. Or that crime was displaced to other areas. Or that officers resented the new ideas and refused to comply. Interviews, questionnaires, and transcripts from community meetings showed a different pattern, a consistent problem about as unsexy as you can imagine: implementation. Even with everyone on board, and the program funded and approved, putting it into practice—getting it to “take”—turned out to be a nightmare.

There were several big roadblocks. First, the police departments obviously had a lot on their agendas. Despite their best intentions, when push came to shove, they struggled to prioritize community policing reforms even though these specific departments had been selected for the study precisely because of their enthusiasm for the program.

For some locations, the roadblock was cultural. In the Philippines, officers got mixed messages from their superiors. Higher-ups endorsed the program but also told them to continue prioritizing the investigation of major crimes instead of the day-to-day problems raised in community meetings. In other locations, the roadblock was institutional. In Pakistan, police were not allowed by law to respond to “noncognizable” crimes (i.e., those requiring a warrant) like domestic abuse, harassment, and financial misconduct. This diminished their ability to address the concerns of the community.

Shifting to community policing may or may not be the best way to [improve law enforcement](#). But if making that change—and making other structural changes like it—is going to be viable, the [boring, pedestrian details of implementation](#) will need close attention.

Sustaining Change: Tree Planting Versus Tree Growing

Tree planting seems innocuous. Who could be against it? But it’s actually much maligned by activists and researchers. Part of the reason is that planting trees is a go-to cause for corporations seeking to [“greenwash” their reputations](#). It helps companies look like they’re on the right side of history without actually having to do much. By August 2020, Salesforce and Mastercard each committed to planting 100 million trees, Timberland 50 million, and Clif Bar 750,000. They all signed on to the “Trillion Tree Initiative,” based on the idea that trees suck carbon pollution out of the air. The initiative was spearheaded by billionaire Marc Benioff, who announced it at the World Economic Forum in Davos, Switzerland. Then President Donald Trump quickly signed on, undoubtedly convincing the world over that he’s “a very big believer in the environment.”

With supporters like these, critics hardly had to point out the terrible track record of tree-planting campaigns. As of 2024, Benioff’s Trillion Tree Initiative has planted 2.6 billion trees—just about 997 billion shy of its goal. Getting trees in the ground isn’t all there is to it either. In the course of planting 11 million trees in 2019, Turkey was recognized by the Guinness Book of World Records for planting the most saplings in one hour and one place (303,150). Within three months, after public attention had moved on to the next thing, 90 percent of those trees were dead. There hadn’t been enough rainfall, and (relatedly)

the saplings had been planted during the wrong season. As one *Vice* headline explained, “Tree-Planting Schemes Are Just Creating Tree Cemeteries.” Another example: India has invested huge sums in large-scale tree planting for decades, but the proportion of forest canopy hasn’t budged. All that the investments have done is shift the composition of the forest away from the broadleaf variety of trees preferred by local people.

All else equal, planting trees isn’t a bad idea. Fully grown trees pull a lot of carbon pollution out of the air. Even if they didn’t, there are good reasons to reforest wild places and get [more trees in urban spaces](#). Still, gathering support, raising money, enacting legislation, and popping a bunch of saplings into the ground isn’t enough. Reaping all those wonderful benefits of trees requires follow-through. As climate scientist Lalisa Duguma put it, “we should just stop thinking about only tree *planting*, it has to be [tree growing](#).”

When tree-growing initiatives are done right, they can have big effects. In southern Brazil, [rural residents \(predominantly women\)](#) have collaborated for over three decades with the nonprofit Institute for Ecological Research to both plant and grow nearly 3 million native trees. These trees provide wood and fruit that local people consume and sell. They also serve as a habitat for threatened species. Replicating this project won’t be easy, but its success makes clear that sustaining change over time is just as important as starting it.

Moments of Liberation and Practices of Freedom

We’ve already hinted at one reason why implementing and sustaining change is difficult: it’s boring. Imagine the thrill of finally winning approval to revamp a major city’s policing practices or landing millions of dollars of funding for a reforestation initiative. Inking the law or getting the first sapling in the ground would be thrilling. Cutting the ribbon can feel like crossing the finish line—but it’s not.

The vital work of implementing and sustaining change feels like a slog by comparison. Working out the minutiae of the officer rotation schedule with fifteen different precinct captains doesn’t have the same allure as reimagining the relationships between the community and the police.

One way to protect against this kind of letdown is by thinking about change differently. Developing concepts for change that help us persist through its many stages can contribute to a commitment to seeing things through.

The writer Maggie Nelson draws inspiration from Michel Foucault’s distinction between “moments of liberation” and “practices of freedom.” Moments of liberation are flashbulb events, like when an oppressed people rises up in revolution against colonial rulers. Statues are toppled, the people gather in the city’s central square. These dramatic episodes are often what come to mind when we think of social change. But focusing too much on [moments of liberation](#) can make it seem like big social change comes all at once, in a single, revolutionary moment. As essential as these moments are, Nelson argues, they’re no replacement for practices of freedom, the persistent struggles for justice that need to follow in their wake.

Daily practices of freedom take different forms for different people—a point we’ll explore in the next chapter. But it’s not just a matter of foisting more responsibility onto people to think differently and sustain change. Practices of freedom are best understood from a both/and perspective. There are also structural conditions that enable and sustain them.

“Keep Your Government Hands Off My Medicare!”

One reason people can fail to support and sustain beneficial changes is that they don’t know about them in the first place. If people aren’t aware of how existing structural reforms benefit them and promote a fairer world, why would they show up morning after morning to keep those reforms going?

Before Obama’s presidency, Congress passed the [Energy Policy Act of 2005](#), which included a loan program for clean energy technologies. As of 2014, the program loaned a total of \$34.2 billion to various

businesses. While it wasn't intended to make money, it ended up being profitable for the federal government. Companies defaulted on \$780 million, but the program recouped \$810 million in interest payments. Far more importantly, it helped kickstart the solar panel industry, driving down prices of panels faster than virtually anyone predicted.

But if anyone heard of this loan program during the 2010s, the overwhelming likelihood is that they associated it with one thing: Solyndra, a solar company that defaulted on its loan. This isn't an accident. Negative TV ads trumpeted Solyndra's default. The FBI raided their headquarters. Republican House Representative Steve Scalise said the Solyndra loan was "disgusting," and so-called moderate Republican Senator Lisa Murkowski called it "a colossal failure." Lost in all this criticism was the fact that the broader loan program both made money and drove the cost of solar down dramatically. It contributed to renewable sources of energy like solar power becoming the cheapest in the world—cheaper than oil, gas, and coal—by the early 2020s.

Critics also failed to mention a similar loan program—Advanced Technology Vehicles Manufacturing—that gave \$465 million to a niche, bespoke car company promising to make sexy electric cars. Tesla was launched with nearly a half billion dollars' worth of government help. Lost to the fog of enactment was that the company repaid the \$465 million nine years ahead of schedule because it was doing—as the comedian Larry David would say—pretty, pretty, pretty good.

Widespread ignorance about successful government programs like these is not a simple result of people failing to pay attention. [Opponents of the programs](#) spread all kinds of nonsense about them, and key to their strategy is playing on people's distrust of government. In this case they were able to connect Solyndra to an older, larger narrative that casts government spending as wasteful and bureaucrats as cutting sweetheart deals for their buddies. Commentators at Fox News and the Wall Street Journal continue to drudge up Solyndra years later to stoke skepticism about federal efforts to promote renewable energy and stem the climate crisis.

The hidden successes surrounding Solyndra's failure represent but a few examples of what political scientist Suzanne Mettler calls the "submerged state." In 2008, she [polled 1,400 Americans](#) to ask if they ever used a government social program; 57 percent said they had not. Then she listed twenty-one federal programs, such as Social Security, unemployment insurance, and student loans, and asked the same people whether they had ever used any of them. Ninety-four percent who declared they had never used a government social program had used one of these twenty-one programs. The average person in the poll had used four!

For these people and many others, the role of the government in shaping their lives is submerged. They fail to realize how they benefit from government programs or even that they're using government programs at all. Those programs and their effects are nearly invisible.

It was in 2009, during the Obamacare debates, when a man angrily yelled during a town hall, "keep your government hands off my Medicare!" The deluge of snarky internet memes mocking him was predictable and immediate. *Slate* set up [a meme tracker](#). Conservative intellectuals leapt to his defense with spurious arguments that Medicare somehow isn't a government social program. (It is. Medicare is a state-run insurance program available to all Americans over sixty-five and some younger people with disabilities and chronic illnesses.)

Mettler's response, however, was both charitable and incisive. She pointed out that one in four people who received Medicare benefits that year accessed them through a private insurance company. Maybe the man wasn't so much in denial about receiving government benefits as he was unaware of the fact that even privately administered health benefits are often a government social program.

This ignorance of government's role is a big problem, and it's [not specific to Medicare](#). Many US hospitals are tax-exempt, for starters. The hospitals themselves were built with federal funding, starting with the 1946 Hill-Burton Act signed by Harry Truman. A big portion of American doctors, nurses, and medical technicians got through their training on federal scholarships. Medical research is often underwritten by the federal government through grants and agencies like the National Institutes of Health, the Federal Drug Administration, and the Centers for Disease Control.

Contrast the American health insurance system, or US investments in clean energy, with influential New Deal programs, like Social Security, or with the GI Bill, and it becomes clear why government programs have become so invisible. People knew all those older programs were helping them, and they knew the government was running them. In the American imagination, these big federal efforts are relics of the past. But Mettler makes a convincing case that the US government has remained active in supporting health, education, and poverty reduction. Federal spending on social goods is roughly [on par with similar nations](#).

And the effects of federal social programs can be very real. In 1964, the [US child poverty rate](#) was 23 percent, while in 2021, it was 11.6 percent. Many people find this shocking. A major reason why people don't know about this drastic reduction lies in the way it's been achieved. Much of the federal effort has been done through low-profile subsidies and tweaks to the tax code. Instead of handing people money, the government cuts their taxes.

Using tax breaks to share American wealth is the result of an understandable but perhaps ill-advised grand political compromise. Progressive policymakers who have sought to use the state to improve people's lives have had to contend with conservatives pushing for lower taxes and fewer government services. These calls for "smaller government" have been common in American public discourse at least since Republican Ronald Reagan was president in the 1980s, when he famously claimed, "[The nine most terrifying words](#) in the English language are: I'm from the Government, and I'm here to help." For our part, we don't find those nine words so scary, at least not compared to conservative activist Grover Norquist, who in 2001 dreamed of shrinking the government "to the size where I can drag it into the bathroom and drown it in the bathtub." But Democrats whose job it is to get bills passed have been forced to acknowledge how appealing the Reagan/Norquist ethos is to many voters. Even Democratic President Bill Clinton declared in 1996 that "the era of big government is over."

All this hostility to big government led Democrats to conclude that the only way to enact problem-solving policies was through the tax code and other [dry technocratic venues](#). If their programs were too visible, they'd get hammered as "big [wasteful, incompetent] government." So—the thinking goes—Democrats have [settled for submerged policies](#).

It's no surprise that the less people see government working for them, the less reason they've got [to want more of it](#). Who would expect them to work their asses off to implement and sustain something, let alone pay more taxes to support it, if they don't even know it's there?

Surfacing the State

The question, then, is how the state and its best social programs can be made more visible. How do we bring these background social structures into the light so that people remain motivated and keep doing the work of sustaining them?

One thing Mettler focuses on is branding. Information about policies that affect the structural conditions of people's lives could be packaged better. For example, Mettler suggests that the federal "government should also [provide 'receipts'](#) that inform people of the size of each benefit they get through the tax code." [Donald Trump had a similar idea](#) when he insisted that his signature appear on the checks issued to citizens that were funded by the first stimulus bill of his first term, though it seemed like he wanted everyone to think the money was coming from his personal checking account rather than the government.

There's evidence that when the benefits of public programs are direct and visible, not only do people recognize the value of the programs themselves but they also become more involved citizens. For example, research suggests that recipients of Social Security and the GI Bill [participated in politics](#) more than they would have otherwise. After seeing what their country could do for them, they did more for their country.

Of course, a big challenge for surfacing the state is that the information environment works a tad bit differently today than it used to. Two-thirds to three-quarters of all American households tuned in to President Roosevelt's "Fireside Chats" in the 1930s and '40s, when he laid out all the advantages of his New Deal programs on all the major radio networks. Yet fewer than one-third of American households

saw Obama's State of the Union addresses. And anything he said in them was instantaneously absorbed by predigested media commentary.

Skeptical that just giving people information like this can make a difference? Mettler's own experiments offer some grounds for optimism. She's tested the effects of making people aware of basic information about policies like the Home Mortgage Interest Tax Deduction and the Earned Income Tax Credit—including information about who benefits the most from such programs. The mortgage deduction takes a sizable chunk out of people's taxes while they're paying off their home. The earned income credit offers a tax break to lower-income working people, especially if they have kids, and lifts millions of people [out of poverty](#). Once people see how active government policies like these relate to their material interests, they become more committed to sustaining them.

The mandate to surface the submerged applies to another arena rife with ignorance and confusion: climate change. The lack of awareness here isn't just about policies, programs, and the state. Most people don't know that most people care about the climate crisis. This is a case of "[pluralistic ignorance](#)," when there are widely shared misperceptions about public opinion. Americans suffer from it badly.

A 2022 paper finds that pluralistic ignorance about climate change is so widespread that we're living in a "false social reality." For example, 66–80 percent of Americans support major climate change mitigation policies, depending on which policies they are asked about. But when asked how popular they think such programs are—that is, when people are asked to guess what percentage of other Americans support these policies—the average answer is 37–43 percent. Put another way, supporters of major climate policies outnumber opponents two to one, but when Americans are asked what their fellow citizens think, they get it exactly backward. They think opponents outnumber supporters two to one.

You don't have to be a political scientist or a marketing whiz to help surface the state and fight American ignorance. Simply learning and talking about the benefits of government programs like Medicare and energy policy is a step in the right direction.

Working the System

There's more to do than talk. One of the most promising cases of successful social change in recent years was due to good customer service. Where the fog of enactment is about the nebulous space between policy passage and policy implementation, the *fog of uptake* is about the space between well-meaning actors implementing a new policy and the intended beneficiaries making actual use of it.

There's a [long-standing debate](#) about why people who live in impoverished neighborhoods tend to stay there. One view is that people stay put because they want to. They have good reasons: remaining close to their families and communities, valuing their neighborhood's culture and diversity, and appreciating the businesses and places of worship tailored to their needs. If they work in those neighborhoods, then their commute is shorter. When Jennifer Morton's strivers feel caught between two different worlds, these are some of the factors keeping them anchored to where they come from. As we said, moving up the socioeconomic ladder too often means moving out of close-knit, supportive communities. When people want to stay put, their preferences should be respected.

Another view is that some people, at least, want to move to different neighborhoods, where there might be better schools and opportunities, but they can't overcome the barriers standing in the way. They might lack information about where to go or how to make it happen. They might lack access to the credit and liquidity needed to rent homes in wealthier neighborhoods. Landlords in those neighborhoods might discriminate against them.

The stakes of this debate are high. Where people live has a huge effect on their lives. Race and class segregation tracks economic opportunities, school quality, healthcare options, and crime. We saw the significance of geography, real estate, and zoning laws to racism back in chapter 2. Part of the perniciousness of segregation is that it cuts people off from economic and social capital (which is about

who you know and how connected you are to opportunities). One analysis found that younger children whose families moved to wealthier neighborhoods had an [annual income 31 percent higher](#) by their mid-twenties than matched kids who didn't move to wealthier neighborhoods.

For all these reasons, people who want to move out of impoverished neighborhoods should be free and able to. There are publicly financed programs aiming to help them do it, providing families thousands of dollars to move. The waitlists for these housing subsidies are long, suggesting demand is strong. Yet the track record of people using them to move to better neighborhoods has been mixed. The two views we described above point toward competing explanations for why subsidies don't deliver reliable results. On the one hand, maybe people say they want to move, but when push comes to shove, they really don't. On the other hand, maybe there's still something standing in their way, even with the generous subsidies.

There's good evidence now, gathered by [a team of social scientists](#) led by Peter Bergman and Raj Chetty, that there are still barriers. The team focused on neighborhoods in Seattle, where local housing authorities have had programs for years providing vouchers to low-income families to encourage them to move to higher-opportunity neighborhoods. As in other places, the uptake of these vouchers for moving to better neighborhoods has been low. The research team tested two different hypotheses about why. They compared a *preferences* model—people don't use vouchers because they don't want to—to a *friction* model—people don't use vouchers because structural barriers get in their way.

In one experiment, they studied 430 families that had applied for and been awarded Housing Choice Vouchers worth on average \$1,540/month in rental assistance. Not chump change! Every family had at least one kid below the age of fifteen, and their median income was \$19,000 per year. Importantly, the vouchers were [scaled to the average neighborhood rent](#), so their value was proportionate in more and less expensive neighborhoods.

The 430 families were divided into two groups. The control group received the standard information, delivered in the standard way, about how to use the vouchers. Families in the treatment group were enrolled in a program called Creating Moves to Opportunity (CMTO), which connected them to a group of “navigators” dedicated to making voucher use easier.

Navigators did three things. First, they provided assistance in searching for apartments, including preparing rental documents, addressing credit issues, and identifying available units in high-opportunity neighborhoods. Second, they acted as liaisons to landlords, encouraging them to rent to CMTO families. Finally, they provided additional financial assistance for things like security deposits and applications fees. In short, CMTO sought to reduce the friction in moving to a better neighborhood. They acted like [good customer service](#) for the families in the program.

To people familiar with the difficulty of creating large impacts in social science experiments, the effect sizes here were breathtaking. Fifteen percent of families in the control group moved to a higher-opportunity neighborhood, whereas 53 percent of those in the CMTO program did. “This is the largest effect I've ever seen in a social science intervention,” Chetty said. The benefits of CMTO were consistent across groups within the program regardless of race, immigration status, and income.

The program affected not only whether people moved but also where they moved. In both the treatment and control groups, approximately 87 percent of families used the vouchers to move. But the CMTO families overwhelmingly moved to higher-opportunity neighborhoods, while other families overwhelmingly didn't. After moving, CMTO families were much more likely to stay put over time and be [“very satisfied”](#) with the new neighborhood.

If residential segregation is the granddaddy of structural barriers to social justice, what this study shows is that a great deal of the most important work in challenging those barriers resides in the nitty gritty business of implementing and sustaining—and not just starting—change. Housing voucher programs exist in many places, and often they're well-funded, like in Seattle. But all that still isn't enough for them to get uptake. The CMTO program is nothing if not a way of making the implementation of a long-standing idea—housing vouchers—work better. Taking up the role of navigator is one way to practice freedom, in this case freedom for those seeking better opportunities. And it's making a tangible difference in people's lives.

Navigating Toward Your Role in Creating Change

Why not work as a navigator for a program like CMT0? It's instrumental in making meaningful change, and it doesn't require wealth, fame, political connections, or a PhD. It *does* require local knowledge, people skills, and patience. If those are in your wheelhouse, maybe it's a role for you.

There are different roles that other people might be better suited to step into as well, depending on what they've got to offer. Some might donate cold hard cash to a project like CMT0. Others might vote for it if it comes up on the ballot. Others might try to craft a viral video about it or even just tell friends about its importance. Seeing a role for yourself is an essential ingredient of making change and making it stick. This is the subject of the next and final chapter: finding our roles for initiating, implementing, and sustaining change.

Fighting from Where You Stand: Finding Your Role in Social Change

My Way of Changing the System Is . . .

A duck glides placidly across the surface of a lake—but underwater its legs are paddling furiously, unseen. You click “Buy Now” on Amazon, and a day or two later a package magically appears at your door—but pulling back the curtain on that “magic” reveals the activity of a whole byzantine empire whose heavy lifting is done by a great many overworked, underpaid, mostly nonunionized laborers. It’s easy to forget all the different roles people fill to keep vast systems like Amazon humming along. The furious underwater paddling is mostly out of sight.

A lot can also remain out of sight as systems change. One day you notice how many office buildings have been vacated and find yourself reflecting on how it all happened so fast, wondering what the seemingly overnight rise of remote work portends for the future. The transition was decades in the making, though, made possible by the development and falling cost of high-speed internet and home delivery services. Then it was accelerated by unaffordable office rents and the COVID-19 pandemic. There were people pushing for it too, like programmers and entrepreneurs at businesses like Skype and Zoom.

The list of roles people can play in the fight for a better world is dizzyingly long. For anyone looking for a place to join the ranks, some personal questions can help narrow it down. Which of all the pressing issues out there do I care about the most? What talents and skills do I have to offer, or am I interested in developing? Which projects are important enough to me that I’ll be willing to stick around through the fogs of enactment and uptake? What are the concrete opportunities I’ve got right in front of me? What are the main forms of friction holding me back? In other words, [what roles am I best positioned to play?](#)

Maybe the best place to start is this: What roles am I playing already? Many struggles are well underway, and even if we don’t realize it, most of us are already in a position to make immediate contributions. “Sometimes we are blessed with being able to choose the time, and the arena, and the manner of our revolution,” Audre Lorde once explained, “but more usually we must [do battle where we are standing.](#)”

Where each of us stands is within a big cluster of social roles: employee, employer, friend, family member, voter, renter, student, teacher, consumer, commuter, pedestrian, surfer, dog walker, cat person, bad art friend, and so on. Each of these roles comes with norms and guidelines—stuff we’re told to do explicitly by higher-ups and stuff we implicitly pick up from imitating others in similar roles. But each role, as the philosopher Robin Zheng points out, also comes with a whole lot of leeway. With that leeway comes distinctive opportunities that anyone occupying the role can take advantage of to make change. This last chapter will look at agents of change who have made the most of their opportunities by leveraging the roles they’ve occupied.

The Lioness of Lisabi

Fela Aníkúlápó Kuti became an international musical sensation in the 1970s. He pioneered Afrobeat, a genre blending West African songs with jazz and funk. But his mother, though less remembered now, was a bigger deal in her time.

Funmilayo Ransome-Kuti came to be known as the “Lioness of Lisabi” for her anti-colonial feminist activism in Nigeria. She was intersectional before it was cool, weaving together analyses of class, gender, local tribal identity, and Pan-Africanism. But much of her early community work [wasn’t explicitly](#)

[political](#). She kicked into gear in 1942, when she founded the Abeokuta Ladies Club, which taught individual women strategies for “self-improvement”—mostly through sewing, catering, and etiquette.

But Ransome-Kuti’s interactions with the diverse ladies of Abeokuta changed her perspective. First a friend who couldn’t read asked her for literacy lessons. Ransome-Kuti obliged and soon after opened her lessons to “market women,” who got by selling food and wares in the city market. Before long, Ransome-Kuti came to see it wasn’t a lack of etiquette or marketable skills holding the market women back. Misogynistic men and sexist structures stood in their way.

Market women were being treated despicably by the Nigerian colonial government. They were extorted, abused, and compelled to pay excessive taxes. Policemen would strip girls naked (and worse) to decide whether they were old enough to pay. Government representatives coerced women into selling goods below market rate only to turn around and resell them to the British for profit.

In 1944, Ransome-Kuti organized a campaign to stop the government’s theft and abuse. Two year later, the Ladies Club became the Abeokuta Women’s Union (AWU). The goal was no longer just to change conditions for individual women; it was to change the system. The AWU demanded genuine political representation. They contacted newspapers, held long vigils, and circulated petitions demanding “no taxation without representation.”

Sensing the seriousness of the threat, the colonial government issued a ban on AWU protests. Ransome-Kuti renamed them “picnics” and “festivals.” Eventually, 20,000 women joined the AWU, at a time when the entire population of Abeokuta numbered less than 100,000. In February 1948, thousands blockaded the government palace, leading to the local ruler’s temporary abdication in 1949. The taxes were finally suspended a few months later. Ransome-Kuti and the AWU had become structure facing. They were people changing systems that change people.

Ransome-Kuti’s influence began to be felt nationally and then internationally. She organized a new political party—the Nigerian Women’s Union—as well as the Federation of Nigerian Women’s Societies. They sought universal suffrage for Nigerian adults, voting accommodations for people who couldn’t read, and quotas allocating positions of power to women. Ransome-Kuti’s work was wide-ranging and decidedly both/and. In the 1960s, she demanded greater healthcare for Nigerians, urging doctors to advise women about maintaining a nutritious diet based on locally grown fruits and vegetables. At the same time, she urged women to appeal to the government to provide structural support for cooperative farming (to make it easier to grow and eat locally). She found time to start schools across the country (dubbing literacy the “weapon of liberty”) and to travel internationally to receive awards and honorary doctorates. She was [given “The Lenin”](#) in 1970.

She also made enemies. In 1977, her son Fela released his hit album *Zombie*, which portrayed Nigerian soldiers as submissive, unthinking drones. Soon after, a thousand soldiers stormed the Ransome-Kuti compound and threw Funmilayo out of a second-floor window. She survived the fall but sustained injuries that took her life a year later. Funmilayo lived to be seventy-seven years old, not quite long enough to see [universal suffrage](#) come to Nigeria in 1979.

Funmilayo Ransome-Kuti didn’t abandon her interest in “self-improvement.” She redirected and broadened it. Unlike the Ladies Club, membership in the AWU was not about learning how to “move up” as an isolated individual in an otherwise unchanged system. It was about developing a critical awareness of the intertwining structures holding Nigerian women and workers back and then drawing on that critical awareness to see what to do to transform the system. Ransome-Kuti learned how to leverage her concrete social roles—her elite position, educated status, and social connections—to adopt new roles, resist the patriarchy, and hasten Nigeria’s exit from the colonial system.

Obviously, not everyone can be a Lioness of Lisabi. Fighting for change requires work and sacrifice, but not everyone will put their lives on the line, decade after decade, in the pursuit of justice and the practice of freedom. Still, there are all kinds of roles people can play in the fight for a better world.

YIMBY

One of the most underappreciated scourges of structural change is the [NIMBY](#). This person supports progressive policies in general (or professes to), but in practice, their support stops short when change affects them personally. They want change somewhere but *Not In My BackYard*. In big blue California, NIMBY resistance has repeatedly blocked plans for building more homes, perpetuating a full-blown humanitarian housing crisis. While writing this book, Alex has lived in a liberal SoCal town that is doing its best to block an affordable development for low-income, unhoused people. NIMBYs are concerned about “[drug dealing and other crimes](#).” (Research consistently shows that subsidized housing doesn’t harm neighborhoods or suppress home values. Sometimes it increases them.) NIMBYs in California have also obstructed other important projects, like high-speed rail lines connecting Los Angeles to San Francisco and Las Vegas.

Not to be outdone by their West Coast counterparts, East Coast elite NIMBYs have organized to block offshore wind power developments (even when they’re ten to fifteen miles offshore and nearly invisible from land), residential rooftop solar installations (claiming they don’t “fit” in historic districts), and more.

Against the NIMBYs have risen up the YIMBYs, people who say *Yes In My BackYard*. More and more, they’ve been [racking up wins](#), even in belly-of-the-beast NIMBY California, where single-unit zoning was banned in 2021. Four states—Vermont, Montana, Rhode Island, and Washington—passed sweeping housing reform legislation in 2023. State legislatures considered 200 other housing supply laws in the same year, from removing restrictions on multifamily apartment buildings to allowing faith-based and educational institutions to build affordable housing on their land. A person can be a YIMBY and support structural change by literally doing nothing and just staying out of change’s way. But a YIMBY can also be a vocal advocate for changes like these, talking up their benefits and touting the advantages of rezoning or sustainable ways of living. Being this kind of YIMBY sends social signals, normalizing YIMBY choices and acting as a role model for others to emulate. When a person embraces YIMBYism, it can spill over into their other personal choices too. Adopting the identity can lead them to seek out opportunities to say yes to other kinds of social change.

The overall effectiveness of the IRA, the US’s signature climate legislation, will be determined not just by what’s written in the law but also by how it gets implemented at local levels—and how it gets stymied by opponents. Exactly how consequential it turns out to be will depend—at least in part—on the struggle between NIMBYs and YIMBYs. If you want to join the fray, there are lots of roles that need filling on team YIMBY. Maybe you can help say yes to a solar farm in your town, recognizing its potential for bringing down energy costs, improving local air quality, and reducing reliance on the larger, less predictable grid. Maybe you can [show up at the zoning board](#) meeting to debate changes to the building code. Meetings like these are underattended and famously dominated by NIMBYs. They’re low-hanging fruit for agents of social change.

Single-Issue Crusader

Saying yes to more housing often means saying no to something else—for instance, places to park cars. There are two billion parking spots in the United States; [seven for every car](#). Parking covers more acres in the country than any other single thing. The culprits, from one point of view, are car companies, urban planners, and aspiring politicians who worked together throughout the twentieth century. One of the most significant things they did was institute minimum parking requirements for new housing and commercial developments across the country. These force developers to provide specific numbers of parking spaces per apartment unit and per square footage of commercial space. Parking spot mandates made it possible to live in one place, work in another, and shop in a third. They were instrumental in creating the physical layout of the US’s deeply WEIRD suburban world.

Now the tide is turning against minimum parking requirements. They’re increasingly seen as impediments to reducing congestion, cleaning the air, building affordable housing, and combating climate change. Hundreds of American cities have overhauled or repealed these laws in recent years, from Buffalo, New York, to San Jose, California, to Anchorage, Alaska. Some developers are providing incentives to would-be customers with allowances for mass transit and car-sharing agreements. Progressive federal

legislators have even tried to get in on the act. Their proposed Yes in My Backyard Act would mandate that awardees of federal community development grants show what steps they're taking to promote affordable housing. One way they can do it is by eliminating parking requirements.

If you want to do research, and you want to do research that affects people's lives, unsexy subjects like parking may give you a better chance than hot button ones like artificial intelligence. You can be a bit of a bigger fish in a smaller pond. In fact, one single person's research is widely credited with helping turn the tide against minimum parking requirements. On Donald Shoup's website, you can read scholarly articles going back to 1968 about zoning and parking rules. His 2005 book *The High Cost of Free Parking* is now considered a classic. His acolytes call themselves Shoupistas.

Shoup didn't turn the tide against parking requirements himself, of course. But he's an example of someone who plugged away for decades in relative obscurity on a single issue that many people would find totally boring. Right up until everyone cared about it and his work made a big impact.

Teacher

Lots of people still want lots of parking near where they live and work. But some things pretty much nobody wants near their backyards, like [factory farms](#). They spread reeking odors and pollutants into neighbors' air, soil, and water. They cause asthma, heart attacks, and acid rain. They're also often located next to marginalized racial and indigenous communities. But factory farms, which furnish 90 percent of the world's meat, aren't just bad for the smells and toxins they pump into the air. They're a big source of carbon pollution. And it probably goes without saying that they subject both animals and employees to atrocious conditions. As a result, more and more people are committing to cutting back on food produced on factory farms. Some become vegetarian or vegan; others become "[reducetarians](#)."

Principled plant eaters are often haunted by a familiar thought, though: that their individual eating choices are just a drop in the bucket. Opting out of eating meat might clear their conscience but fail to make a dent on the factory farm industry. But what if they can scale up the consequences of their role by convincing others to join in? Sounds nice: after all, everyone loves being lectured about the virtues of veganism!

Under the right conditions, however, persuasion seems possible. [An ethics class](#) with a unit on the evils of factory farming might be just the place, or so several studies suggest. In one, students in two large classes read an influential essay about animal suffering on factory farms. Their responses were compared to students in other classes who read about a different issue (the ethics of charity). All the students (1,143 in total) discussed the essays in smaller-sized, fifty-minute meetings with their teaching assistants. Then they filled out questionnaires about their likelihood of donating money to charity and eating meat. The students were also sent vouchers they could use for on-campus dining. The results? Modest but meaningful.

Their stated values changed significantly. Forty-three percent of students who learned about animal suffering agreed that "eating the meat of factory farmed animals is unethical," while only 29 percent of those who got the lesson about charitable giving did. Before the intervention, in both groups, about 30 percent of the students' purchases at the campus cafeterias contained meat. Afterward, that percentage fell to 23 for students in the animal ethics class but stayed steady for students in the charitable giving class. The effects [lasted at least a couple months](#).

For teachers, parents, coaches, and would-be role models, evidence for even modest effects like these is terrific news. It's a welcome balm for the creeping cynicism that has become an occupational hazard for so many of us. Maybe we don't always come off as Charlie Brown's parents wah-woo-wah-ing on the trombone. Maybe sometimes the message actually gets through.

Eating less meat may have modest impact by itself, but as we learned in chapter 7 "*my choices are your situation*," and so no single person's choices are really just their own. Who knows what that lone student who takes the animal rights lesson to heart might go on to do? Eating less meat also helps shape the situations in which you make your own future choices. Who knows what you might go on to do?!

It's unclear what's driving the effects in the ethics class, but we suspect one factor is the teachers' effectiveness. Recall what an impassioned leader like Devine can do in a classroom, encouraging a mindset of growth and empowerment in their students, and compare that to some backbencher who's just phoning it in.

Sponsor

One role model of ours is Jennifer Nagel, who occupies the role of philosopher at the University of Toronto. Now, philosophers are somewhat notorious for talking the talk without walking the walk. Nagel wonderfully subverts this stereotype. During the Syrian refugee crisis of 2015, like many others, she was appalled by the image of a drowned three-year-old who had washed up on the shore in Turkey, trying to flee from the war in his homeland. "As a Canadian," she wrote, "[there was something more I could do.](#)"

She decided to take advantage of a Canadian immigration policy that allows private citizens to sponsor refugee families. Nagel posted about it on Facebook, organized the fifteen friends who responded, and filled out the simple two-page form. After she passed a background check, she soon found herself organizing the arrival of a family—a widow and five of her children who had been living in a refugee camp in Lebanon. The sponsorship lasted a year and involved considerable work, from finding a doctor and school for the family to helping them shop for groceries. But the family became self-sufficient and changed Nagel's perspective in the process.

She tells us she reflects on the experience with a real sense of appreciation for how much people from very different places can learn from each other, stressing that the learning went both ways:

This family didn't have much, materially, but they really knew how to live. I'd go over to their apartment to get them to sign some kind of school form, hoping to be in and out in ten minutes, and it would always take two hours, because we'd have to have coffee, which would be prepared very slowly, and served on a tray. Then we would look at pictures on people's phones, and talk about everything that had happened since we saw each other, and about all our mutual acquaintances, with Google Translate barely enabling us to converse.

It was exasperating at first, but I realized over time that I had been making a mistake in my life, always being in a rush to get things done, and they were getting it right. I learned a lot from them, about everything from their religion to the hidden workings of my city, and we're still in touch.

[Canada's history of refugee sponsorship](#) is grounded in a commitment to upholding international rights, which was itself spurred by Canadian churches and neighborhood groups moved by the plights of people fleeing persecution. But evidence also suggests that—while the work of hosting is intensive and expensive—Canada's privately sponsored refugees end up better integrated and employed than refugees admitted solely with government assistance. And reams of data clarify how migration, including from refugees, benefits host countries. More immigration leads to stronger economies and innovation in culture and business.

But immigration has costs too, especially in the short term. Newcomers suffer a dip in well-being after moving, in part because immigration is arduous, in part because they suffer discrimination. NIMBYs and housing shortages don't help either. There are political costs too, at least from a progressive perspective. Sharp spikes in immigration can lead to commensurate spikes in support for radical right-wing parties. Sweden shocked the world in September 2022 when, after decades of dominance by progressive and center-left politics, recent waves of immigration were followed by the election of a far-right coalition. This result came to seem less shocking by 2025, as far-right parties gained electoral ground the world over.

Backlash like this doesn't affect all white people the same. People who feel strongly identified with their white ethnicity are more likely to react this way. In contrast, white people who feel [less attached to their racial identity](#) are readier to be sponsors in the vein of Jennifer Nagel. (The power of racial identification to

either drive or dull white backlash is another reminder: all politics is identity politics.)

The downsides of spikes in immigration tend to be short-lived. For those who migrate, [well-being eventually improves](#). For the countries that take them in, initial boosts in support for populist right-wing parties also fade over time. What drives both these positive longer-term trends is intergroup contact. Students get immersed in their new culture at school; adults get to know one another; trust slowly builds.

But as we found in chapter 5, not every form of intergroup contact does the trick. It's important that people be on equal footing and have opportunities to pursue goals together. College campuses offer a great example. For students attending diverse colleges, stereotypes about out-groups diminish. The effect is especially pronounced for students randomly assigned to interracial roommates.

Learning-oriented mindsets matter here too. When philosophy professors from Toronto host refugees from Syria, help them to enroll their children in school, and celebrate seasonal feasts together, they're ready to learn and work as equals toward shared goals.

The seeds sown from one role can bear fruit that grows into another. Many of today's refugee sponsors were themselves sponsored in the past. In 2016, almost [forty years after coming to Canada](#) from Vietnam at the age of five, Nhung Tran-Davies sponsored a Syrian refugee family. Like the doubly empowered DREAMers we met in chapter 11, many former refugees become politically engaged leaders.

As with housing vouchers in Seattle, Canada's private sponsorship program for refugees was already on the books. But securing uptake for these programs takes people stepping into "sustainer roles" like housing navigators and migration sponsors.

Happy Warrior

This book has profiled a wide range of people who took their roles to a whole other level, demonstrating degrees of commitment, ingenuity, and sacrifice few will match. But everyone's life provides all sorts of smaller windows for doing good, making a difference, and catalyzing change.

Random acts of kindness are a great example. In one experiment, participants offered free hot chocolate to someone at a public skating rink. This small kindness delivered big jolts of joy to recipients and givers alike, a result replicated in numerous similar studies. Yet many people remain unlikely to do little good deeds like this, for an all-too-familiar reason: they consistently underestimate the personal and social consequences of their actions. Again and again, people forget how much impact their actions have, on others and themselves. That's partly because they forget [how much impact others have had on them](#).

Some people do manage to remember. One study interviewed hospital cleaning staff, finding that some saw their jobs as dreary and low skilled, while others saw their work as meaningful and high skilled. The difference, explains psychologist Amy Wrzesniewski, was driven by proactive engagement with doctors, nurses, and patients. Some staff members described the importance of paying attention to the cleanliness of the hospital room ceilings since they could imagine patients having to stare at the ceiling all day. Others said to themselves: "this could be my father or my mother or my brother or sister, and how would I care for them?"

These hospital staff members are using their leeway to do what Wrzesniewski calls "job crafting," (re)defining their roles in ways that focus on meaning and change. And it's not just jobs that can be crafted like this. When we show up for someone, just to be there for them, we're crafting a relationship. We can also use our leeway to perform random acts of kindness. It's another way to be a [happy warrior](#), helping ourselves and those around us have a better time while we're fighting for a better world.

Conclusion

Time Doesn't Tell; We Tell Time

“Drys”—as teetotalers and temperance advocates were known—must have been devastated looking back on the ruins of their cause. After nearly a century of activism, they revised the Constitution of the United States, only [to see their work backfire](#). In the fight for social change, what looks like victory can dissolve into failure.

On the other hand, what looks like defeat can turn into success. The League of Nations seemed like one of the most colossal failures in modern history. Established in the aftermath of World War I, it was the first transnational organization whose mission was to prevent war and promote world peace. The founding agreement, infused with postwar zeal, promised a fundamental departure from the international system of the nineteenth century. US President Woodrow Wilson won the Nobel Peace Prize for spearheading its creation. Then the United States refused to join. The organization dedicated to ensuring world peace succumbed to the world's worst war in less than twenty years.

Facing such setbacks, Robert Cecil, an architect of the League and another Nobel Peace Prize winner, took a longer view. On August 18, 1946, at its final meeting, he proclaimed, “The League is dead. Long live the United Nations.” As the forerunner to the United Nations, [the League's legacy](#) has been overwhelmingly positive. It began the process of institutionalizing the rule of law, sparked interest in and theorizing about collective security, and gave smaller nations a bigger voice than ever before. It turned global attention to shared problems like epidemics, slavery, child labor, and refugee crises.

Without the benefit of hindsight, it's hard to [tell the successes from the failures](#). And no one can predict the future. Stories of the past provide guidance, though. They shape the paths we chart into the future. Before World War II, people called World War I the “Great War.” It was only after the horrors of Auschwitz, Pearl Harbor, Hiroshima, and Dresden that world wars were assigned numbers like movie sequels. This numbering has consequences. Ever since World War II, people have wondered, “What might World War III be like?” Thinking of World War I and II as a sequence makes us brace for more to come.

It's true that only time will tell what happens next. But it's also true that time is ours to tell. [History is remembered, and told, by people](#). How we remember directs what we look for and find. Our stories become lessons that shape the events that we spin new stories about.

We've told many stories in this book. We started with one about how large corporations conspired to dupe us into futile forms of individualism, saddling us with responsibility for the carbon we emit and [the hate we give](#). Those stories push us to consume better and recycle more. When it comes to fighting racism and sexism, they imply that our main job is to root out our internal biases, to master our own minds.

This propaganda has been effective, leaving many of us believing individualist fairytales that “real change comes from within” and social change starts with each of us on our own.

These stories retain incredible power, often propping up the status quo. It's a testament to their power that activists, politicians, and citizens intent on making change fall so easily under their sway. That includes us and our environment-themed bar mitzvahs. (Well, really, just one environment-themed bar mitzvah. And it was a long time ago!)

It can be tempting to completely reverse course, to swing all the way in the other direction. Abandon not just the idea that individual change “comes first” but that personal choices matter *at all*. Champion the view that we need to change the system directly.

But these responses to rampant individualism just substitute one monolithic, oversimplified, either/or view for another. The stories in this book all try to show how policies and people, institutions and ideas are thoroughly intertwined and mutually reinforcing. Both need to change, and there's no real sense to be

made of the question of which to change first or which is more important. As the people who change systems that change people, we can work on both simultaneously. Considering who we are and how we're situated within social networks, we can see how being pressured by our peers shows that we're capable of pressuring them in return. The roles we occupy, whether we inherit or adopt them, give us real options. We can be housing navigators, antibias innovators, coalition-building DREAMers, or even just happy warriors.

As Tamin Ansary put it, the ceaseless task is to “[keep correcting our narrative.](#)” One kind of story misses the structural duck by focusing too much on the individualist rabbit. Another turns its back on the individualist rabbit, mistaking it as nothing but corporate propaganda. The world needs big structural change. Filling it with the right kinds of stories can help it get there. Perhaps you'll go on to change some systems yourself and contribute a duck-rabbit story of your own. As the powerful play goes on, maybe you will contribute a verse.